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Understanding the Relationship Between Black Chicago Youth and Chicago Drill Music Culture

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**UNDERSTANDING THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN THE YOUNG BLACK
CHICAGO COMMUNITY AND CHICAGO DRILL MUSIC CULTURE**

Doctoral Applied Research

Submitted to the Graduate Faculty of National Louis University, Chicago College of Education

In Partial Fulfillment
of the Requirements for the Degree of Doctor of Education
Organizational Leadership in College of Arts and Science

By Dan'iel T. Kendricks

April 2022

**UNDERSTANDING THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN THE YOUNG BLACK
CHICAGO COMMUNITY AND CHICAGO DRILL MUSIC CULTURE**

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UNDERSTANDING THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN THE YOUNG BLACK CHICAGO
COMMUNITY AND CHICAGO DRILL MUSIC CULTURE

FINAL EDITING COMPLETED

Dr. Dan Kirkpatrick

Digitally signed by Dr. Dan Kirkpatrick
Date: 2022.06.13 11:22:30 -05'00'

Signature of University Approved Editor

FINAL DEFENSE

04/25/2022

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ABSTRACT

Chicago is most noted as a beautiful, Midwestern city, set to the backdrop of Lake Michigan, with skyscrapers and the bustling energy of the downtown Magnificent Mile. The “Tale of Two Cities,” Chicago is a city full of hope, opportunity, and potential for some, but a city plagued with poverty, violence, disinvestment, and hopelessness for others. There has been a significant increase in the awareness of the violence happening across Chicago. The emergence of social media has provided a direct and unfiltered view of the reality of violence the city has faced on an ongoing basis. Crimes such as shootings, carjacking, and gang violence are constantly thrust into the spotlight and often captured and discussed in mainstream and social media. The internet has become an essential aspect of everyday life for most of us. The explosion of social media and music/video streaming platforms has created a means by which Black Chicago youth capture the realities of their world. The virtual world of likes, shares, and hashtags has created an algorithm, leading viewers a few short clicks away from experiencing the “Ghettaverse,” an immersive virtual experience of poverty, violence, and gang life in Chicago. The popularity of likes and shares combined with a global hunger for ghetto and poverty voyeurism has created a path for the poorest residents of Chicago from the most adversely impacted communities to derive a strategy to reap benefits from the digital economy. Black Chicago youth are sharing “hood” stories and experiences with millions of individuals worldwide through music and video streaming. Black Chicago youth have gained worldwide notoriety for creating Chicago drill music. The qualitative data for this study suggest that Black Chicago youth engage in creating and listening to navigate the poverty and violence experienced in their environment. This study led to the understanding of how Black Chicago youth engage in Chicago drill music culture as a way to interpret their experiences while amplifying their voices to meet their own needs.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I would like to express my deepest appreciation and gratitude to all that supported me during this journey. The consistent dedication of your time, effort, and support has allowed me to reach this pivotal moment. I would like to acknowledge the village of caring teachers and adults at Marva Collins Westside Preparatory school, which provided me with the love, support, and educational foundation that has brought me to this chapter: Dr. Bradley Olson, Dr. Erika Mingo, Dr. Judah Viola, Dr. Jacqueline Anderson, Dr. Paviella Foster, Grace Wright, Olympha Chatman, Shana McKinney, Alana Davis, Ignite Staff, Sharron Beverly, Pamela Davis, and Steve Daniel. I would like to extend the greatest appreciation to my mother and father, Ms. Barbara Kendricks and Mr. Ervin Kendricks, and to my family for always giving me your unconditional love and support.

DEDICATION

I dedicate this dissertation to God, my village of loving family and friends, and most of all, my daughter. Gabrielle Savannah Kendricks, may you see the works of this product and be inspired to always be UNAPOLOGETICALLY you, LOVE who you are, EMBRACE your journey, and SHINE your light on this world.

The child who is not embraced by the village will burn it down to feel its warmth.

—*African Proverb*

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CHAPTER ONE: INTRODUCTION

Locals often regard life in Chicago as the “Tale of Two Cities.” The beautiful, landscaped city, set to the backdrop of Lake Michigan, is lined by astonishingly designed architectural skyscrapers and the bustling energy of the downtown Magnificent Mile, a Midwestern city full of hope, opportunity, and potential for some but a city plagued by violence, despair, and hopelessness for others. There has been a significant increase in the awareness of violence happening across Chicago. The emergence of social media has provided a direct and unfiltered view of the continuing reality of violence the city faces. Crimes such as shootings, carjacking, and gang violence are often thrust into the spotlight and often captured and discussed in mainstream and social media. The adverse conditions impacting the South and West Side communities of Chicago, such as poverty, inadequate housing, educational achievement gaps, unemployment, and overall lack of opportunity in Chicago, are not issues that are widely discussed in popular media, nor are the issues of structural violence connected to the increase in criminal behavior plaguing the city.

The emergence of the COVID-19 pandemic exacerbated the already challenging conditions facing some Chicago communities. The COVID-19 pandemic has brought to the forefront significant health issues facing Black communities across Chicago. According to the Chicago Department of Public Health (2020), 45.6% of confirmed COVID-19 cases were Black, and 20.4% were White. Blacks in Chicago account for 56% of the COVID-19-related deaths in Chicago, while Whites represent 15.8%. According to Kim and Bostwick (2020), “These numbers stand in contrast to the racial make-up of the city of Chicago, which is 30.1% non-Hispanic African American and 32.8% White” (p. 509). In addition to health disparities experienced by the Black community, the live capture and unearthing of the murders of George

Floyd, Ahmuad Arbery, Laquan McDonald, and countless other Black lives in the United States outraged millions in an already highly polarized environment. The combination of these events sparked strong reactions across the nation, including peaceful demonstrations and civil unrest. In Chicago, these events, coupled with increased crime, joblessness, housing instability, and school closings, have spilled over to create serious health and safety issues for all of those living in the city. Young Black Chicagoans are continually identifying ways to process and navigate these issues. Not only are these situations present in their physical environments; they also exist in their virtual environment.

As assessed from an epidemic perspective, violent behavior circulates and spreads through ongoing exposure through social and face-to-face interactions (Patton, McGregor et al., 2018). In 2021, violence exposure has moved beyond the traditional face-to-face and social interactions and is now embedded in and rapidly spread through digital and virtual transmissions. Social media's growth, voyeurism, and consumerism have manifested violent behavior in digital environments. The rapid growth of technology, combined with the popularity of ghetto voyeurism in social media and increased isolation of Chicago communities on the South and West Side, increased unemployment, lack of programming for youth, lack of access to mental health, the gentrification of Chicago neighborhoods, rapid transmission of violent behavior and public infatuation with ghetto poverty culture has created an environment rich for the birth of Chicago drill music culture.

The Internet has become essential to our global society. The Internet has created the opportunity for people worldwide to share news, information, updates, and conduct business. The great digital divide highlights the challenges associated with access to the Internet, modality of Internet use, and function/purpose of use when accessing the Internet. The evolution of digital

access using smartphones combined with the growth of social media networks has provided a platform for all individuals to share the realities of their life day to day. Social media sites such as Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram were once utilized as platforms for students, families, friends, and colleagues to stay connected without the boundaries of time, space, and distance. The explosion of social media platforms in recent years and the over-representation of usage by Black youth accessing social media has created a means by which Black communities are able to capture the reality of their world. In Chicago, this has meant exposing the harsh conditions and traumas of living in the most adversely impacted communities of Black Chicago neighborhoods.

The social media world of shares, hashtags, and algorithms has inadvertently created a direct virtual “ghettaverse” access, an upfront view of Chicago’s poverty, violence, and gang life. The popularity of “sharing” life combined with the increased infatuation with ghetto and poverty voyeurism in popular media has also created a path for the poorest residents of Chicago, from the most adversely impacted communities, to derive a strategy to reap benefits from sharing stories and experiences with millions of individuals from communities around the world, while also leveraging an opportunity gain worldwide notoriety and a means of income to escape the poverty and violence of their Chicago block (hood). The chance of “making it out” and the opportunity to gain respect or to be seen as an important and valued individual, gain financial stability, and relish in virtual clout, is a route that many young Black Chicagoans are willing to take, regardless of the level of risk involved.

On August 4, 2020, a popular Chicago drill rapper known by the stage name of FBG Duck was shot and killed in the popular Chicago downtown Gold Coast area. FBG Duck was a member of the “Fly Boy Gang,” often abbreviated “FBG.” FBG Duck was reportedly a member of the Gangster Disciples street gang faction known as the “St. Lawrence Boys.” FBG Duck was

shot dead when four gunmen emerged from two cars as he shopped in Chicago's high-end shopping district. The murder was suspected to be retaliation against FBG Duck for the recent release of a song and music video in which he mentioned the names of dead rivals.

On September 21, 2021, 15-year-old Chicago drill rapper Jamari Williams, also known by his stage name "Rio Son," was gunned down just after being let out from his classes at Simeon High School, located in Chicago's South Side West Chatham community. Jamari was not far from the school when a black car drove up, and two people began firing at him, striking him in the chest. Williams' murder was rumored to be connected to the recent YouTube release of his drill song "Dead Opps."

The deaths of young talented Chicago rap artists such as Lil JoJo, FBG Duck, Jamari Williams "Rio Son," OTF Nunu, Pac Man, L'A Capone, Blood Money, and many more have become common occurrences, as many young Chicago rappers and their affiliates continue to risk and lose their lives to gun and gang-related violence. As the popularity of Chicago's drill music culture continues to grow and expand internationally, the epidemic of gun violence and gang-related murders continues to impact young Black Chicago. In a press conference held in Chicago, October 2021, federal attorneys working for the U.S. Attorney's Office of Northern Illinois handed down murder indictments for the murder of Carlton Weakley, also known as "FBG Duck," to five Black males from Chicago's Parkway Garden low-income housing, also known as "O'Block." The attorneys blame Chicago drill music for influencing crime across the city and specifically cited that members of the O'Block street gang had committed the murder and used music and social media to publicly claim responsibility for acts of violence across the city to increase their criminal enterprise as Chicago drill music culture continues to generate millions of dollars in the music industry and on streaming platforms, alongside millions of views

and likes on social media. Despite the fame and notoriety of many Chicago drill music artists, drill induces a negative reaction from many. Many artists have been blacklisted from performing within the Chicago city limits, yet young Black Chicagoans across the city continue to connect with Chicago drill music culture and utilize it as an outlet to share their unfiltered stories and the raw truth of their daily experiences of life in Chicago. Despite its negative persona, Chicago drill music has also offered many Black Chicago males an opportunity to gain notoriety, financial stability, and an avenue to make it out of the Chicago hood. It is worthwhile to conduct qualitative analysis to explore the connection between young Black Chicago and the interconnected relationship with Chicago drill music culture while providing insight and raising awareness about the realities, traumas, and ingenuity many young Black Chicagoans demonstrate as they navigate their daily conditions.

Purpose of the Study

The popularity of the Chicago drill music culture has garnered the attention of an international audience. The rapidly increasing gun violence in Chicago, in combination with the growing popularity of Chicago drill music, has thrust Chicago into the international spotlight. Chicago drill music provides a real-time musical soundtrack for many young Black Chicagoans from Chicago's most disadvantaged and adversely impacted communities. *Drill* is a Chicago South Side slang term, originally used by young teens and young adults to describe wild partying and uncontrollable fun. As the term *drill* grew in popularity, it quickly took on new meaning. The young, party-hard, fast, and exciting "turn-up" lifestyle soon began to become intertwined with young Chicago street gang members.

The growing evolution of Chicago street culture from neighborhood to the virtual world, combined with the evolution of technology, digital access, smartphones, and app development,

created a means for many to create content, news, and music without the need for expensive studio settings. The explosion of social media gave many Black Chicagoans an opportunity to create unfiltered real-life content that reflected their everyday lives and neighborhood. The rapidly deteriorating socioeconomic conditions in some Chicago neighborhoods, the gentrification of redline communities of the South and West Side, public school closings and consolidation, and increased feeling of hopelessness soon gave a way for Chicago youth to tell the stories of their block, neighborhood, gang/street affiliations and feuds to a worldwide audience. An industry that was once dominated by record labels, high-end production studio settings, and distribution contracts had now been simplified and could be accessed through a palm-held smart device. This would soon allow many street-involved Chicago young teenagers and adults to create music, content, beats, and videos telling their experiences with the potential of leading to fame, money, and stardom. With the major growth of social media, free content creation tools, and music/video production, guns and the hood as a virtual production set, the word “drill” or “to do a drill” suddenly took on new meaning. Chicago drill music had become inevitably interlaced with young Black Chicago, street life, gang affiliations, and retaliation, painting a realistic and grim snapshot of the real-life and meta-hood experiences and violence faced by many young people on the South Side of Chicago.

Set to the sound of the heavy 808-bass blares, inaudible adlibs, gunshot sound effects, mumble rap, and violent gang influenced retaliatory lyrics, combined with a music video backdrop filled with young individuals signifying gang affiliations and brandishing heavy weaponry, Chicago drill music culture made its international debut in the hip-hop industry. The distinctly harsh and drastically different sound and messaging of Chicago drill music abandoned the messaging of typical rap artists’ aspirations to achieve upward mobility and live an

extravagant life outside the “hood.” Drill music embraces struggle and day to day survival by any means necessary and tells the raw experiences of life in the slums and trenches of Chicago, demonstrating an immobilized connection between the music, street life, and poverty/violence in Chicago.

The growing popularity of the Chicago drill music has stepped into the spotlight as the rap industry’s new sound representing the “new Chicago Movement,” an unapologetic voice highlighting the bootstrap efforts of young Black Chicagoans’ daily experiences and embracing efforts to pull themselves out of poverty and disadvantaged communities by way of the digital economy. Chicago drill music is often characterized as “gang music” or “block music,” promoting high-risk violent lifestyles and maladaptive survival behavior. Though shunned by many police districts, political officials, and other public figures, Chicago drill music has been embraced as the voice that represents the experience of many young black Chicagoans from the most disinvested and violent communities of Chicago.

Drill music embraces the ghettoization, criminalization, neighbor-“hood” segregation, and violence experienced by young Black Chicago. Resilience is described as an individual’s ability to recover from extreme adverse and traumatic experiences. An individual’s resilience represents a powerful combination and willingness to adapt and survive while enduring exposure to adverse experiences. The violent narrative of drill music and vilification of young Black Chicago drill artists and surveillance of their activities in real life and on social media has been the targeted focus, with less attention or discussion given to the structural violence and marginalized communities these young people come from and the savviness and ingenuity they have demonstrated to hack and take ownership of the music industry from the Chicago slums with just a cell phone are often overlooked. The purpose of this study was to understand the

relationship between Black Chicago youth and drill music culture. Last, this study tried to empower, build, and uplift the savvy and innovation young Black Chicagoans demonstrate daily to survive as they navigate poverty and the adverse conditions of Black Chicago.

CHAPTER TWO: LITERATURE REVIEW

The Black Belt: Segregation and Opportunity Gaps in Chicago

The “American dream,” home and property ownership, a career or business with stable income, access, and achievement of higher education, have long served as the means for building wealth in the United States. Systemic practices such as red lining and the denial of mortgages to Blacks long served as the blueprint to denying Black Chicago access to achieving the “American dream” or the possibility of upward mobility. Wealth is a measure of assets that an individual or family owns, such as a home, retirement accounts, and money in the bank, minus the amount of debt the individual or family owes at a given time. A sustainable and livable income, property ownership with appreciating value, owning a profitable business, savings/retirement accounts, and investing are key factors that allow individuals and families to build wealth in the United States. Households also build wealth by passing financial stability from one generation to the next through practices such as inheritance, generating funds to pay for tuition and post-secondary educational cost, purchasing or providing a down payment on a home, or providing other means of financial cushions that prevent the family’s adult children from going into debt.

The racial wealth gap is the measurement of the income, saving, and asset gap between White households versus Black and Latino households. Across the United States, White households earn, on average, 10 times more than Black households and 8 times more than Latin households (The Chicago Community Trust, 2020). This is especially demonstrated in Chicago due to decades of astounding government policies and practices, leading Chicago to become one of the most segregated cities in the United States. In the early 20th century, government practices such as legislative redistricting redrew the boundaries for the Chicago housing market and school districts. Along with exclusionary zoning laws and restrictive covenants, these government

practices kept Blacks in Chicago limited to living only in certain areas and forming what is now referred to as the “Black belt” on Chicago’s South Side.

According to the Racial Wealth Divide Initiative at the Corporation for Enterprise Development (CFED), the demographic profile of Chicago consists of 32% White, 31% Black, 29% Latino, and 6% Asian American. Crain’s Chicago Business (Rodkin, 2018) reported that when examining homeownership, Chicago has the biggest gap between White and Black households in the nation when comparing large metropolitan areas. Though Blacks, Whites, and Latinos are equally represented in Chicago demographics, 74% of Whites own their home compared to 39% of Blacks (Rodkin, 2018).

The ramifications of oppressive government practices have far-reaching implications spanning beyond the Chicago real estate market. The impact of these practices has extended to being the root cause in Black communities across Chicago experiencing inequities in health care, disparities in accessing financial services, and restricting access to quality education. The gap in Black homeownership in Chicago directly represents Black Chicagoans having a lack of access to stable neighborhoods, less accrual of wealth/savings, and being at a disadvantage in pursuit of achieving upward economic mobility.

Harvard professor and economist Raj Chetty has earned notoriety for his studies on economic mobility and for his development of the Opportunity Atlas, a tool that uses census data and income tax return information to track economic mobility across the country (Kang, 2019). According to Chetty, one of the worst places for Blacks, particularly Black males, to achieve upward mobility is Chicago. According to Petty, Chicago has the largest economic mobility gap across the 50 states, and this is due largely to the incredible segregation of Chicago’s neighborhoods (Kang, 2019). Kang stated that opportunities for upward economic mobility for

Black children growing up in the heart of Chicago are extremely poor due to poor educational outcomes, increased rates of crime, and the lack of access to mentoring and other social support networks that might support personal growth. Chetty stated that this is especially true for Black men in Chicago, which may suggest a correlation between interaction with the criminal justice system and the cycle of Black men with low-income becoming involved in street life, crime, and becoming incarcerated, which ultimately impacts opportunity for an upward economic trajectory (Kang, 2019). Chetty cited that from a high-level view, Chicago appears to be a very vibrant and progressive city that is doing extremely well. However, this is only true for White families. Despite the appearance of a thriving Windy City, Chicago has left behind a vast population of residents confined to certain blocks within the larger neighborhood (Kang, 2019).

The Fall of Chicago Housing Projects and Rise of Gentrification

During the 1990s, the Chicago Housing Authority (CHA) owned and managed 17 housing projects, responsible for owning, managing, and housing 5% of the city's population. Chicago has the third-largest public housing system in the United States (Chyn, 2018). Chicago projects were generally comprised of a collection of high-rise buildings and row-house-style apartments built in very close proximity. The Chicago Housing Authority's high-rise buildings would house 75-150 units for families with children (Chyn, 2018). Households eligible for public housing were eligible if the household was at or below 50% of the Chicago median income. Families often spent years on the public housing waiting list and often accepted the first available opening. During this time, most Chicago housing project residents were Black, single-parent, female-headed households (Chyn, 2018). In the 1990s, it was revealed that the Chicago Housing Authority was experiencing serious infrastructure and housing management issues, which included serious maintenance issues, mismanagement of funding, and violence in the

actual project communities. The type of violence that occurred in CHA housing projects is rarely discussed. Some of the most egregious incidents have made it into the public media. However, most people would find the daily violence in these settings unsettling and reprehensible (Adams, 2016).

During the late 1990s, the CHA planned to gradually reduce the number of project-based housing assistance vouchers while simultaneously beginning to demolish public housing structures across the city. The demolition of the CHA public housing units disproportionately impacted Black communities and further exacerbated segregation in an already heavily segregated city (Hagedorn & Rauch, 2007). In the 1950s, then Chicago Mayor Richard Daley refused to integrate or build public housing structures into non-Black neighborhoods. Instead, Daley overpopulated public housing structures into predominantly Black Chicago neighborhoods; nearly all Chicago housing projects were built in communities with a 90% Black population (Hagedorn & Rauch, 2007). This decision further reinforced racial segregation and the geographical and financial housing boundaries within the city.

CHA unveiled its “Plan for Transformation” in 2000. This plan led to the demolition and forced displacement of over 100,000 Black residents. The Plan for Transformation included a relocation strategy for qualified residents allowing them to use a low-income voucher to obtain a subsidy on qualifying existing housing. The caveat to this CHA strategy is that the housing did not exist. CHA had plans to serve only 15% of residents through the relocation strategy. Of the residents assisted by the CHA relocation strategy, 97% moved into other non-opportunity areas across the city (Hagedorn & Rauch, 2007). The demolition of Chicago Housing projects and displacement of CHA residents had a massive impact on the breakdown of Black neighborhoods.

Understanding the Past and Present of Chicago Gangs

Federal and local law enforcement agencies allege that Chicago is home to over 100 street gangs, with an overall membership of as many as 150,000 (Aspholm, 2020). Chicago is home to some of the country's oldest, largest, and most notorious street gangs, including the Gangster Disciples, Latin Kings, Black Disciples, Black P Stones, Mickey Cobras, Four Corner Hustlers, and Vice Lords, among many others. It is estimated that Illinois has the highest per-capita gang membership in the country (Aspholm, 2020).

Chicago street gangs have been counted as the country's largest and most organized gang structures. These gangs were primarily founded from the 1950s to 1970s on the South and West Side of the city and operated under a very vertical hierarchy structure. During this period, many Black families and communities were shattered due to the demise of the industrial sector, climbing unemployment, dilapidated neighborhood conditions, soaring incarceration, the crack cocaine epidemic, and the War on Drugs.

The creation of the Chicago Black Belt, combined with the development and demolition of Chicago's housing projects, has had a widespread and far-reaching impact on the city. Public housing demolition in Chicago led to the displacement of hundreds of thousands of Black households. Additional unintended effects of CHA's public housing demolition and resident relocation strategy additionally led to the fracturing of dozens of Chicago street gangs. Gangs that previously controlled the drug market within specific geographical housing settings had now been relocated and engaged in turf wars to claim territory controlled by preexisting street gangs in that neighborhood (Hagedorn & Rauch, 2007). Chicago housing policy, combined with Chicago law enforcement strategies, led to the arrest of seasoned ranking institutionalized Chicago gang members, leaving the Chicago street gangs lawless with no sense of order or

structure. Younger gang members were left without structure and experienced leaders. The displacement and targeted removal/incarceration of high-ranking gang leadership predictably led to increased conflict, violence, and homicides across the city (Hagedorn & Rauch, 2007).

Chicago drill rapper G-Herbo accounted in a 2016 interview with the Breakfast Club the heightened fear of violence that he experienced traveling home each night:

I remember walking in the house with my gun in my hand, out walking through my momma hallway, all the lights off, the whole hallway door open, and my grandmother literally, my grandmother, I gotta go to her house every day, 'cause I live with my grandmother, but she live in the enemy neighborhood, people trying to kill me on the same block that my grandmother live on. This is my house. I have to go here every night, so I remember coming from that. You know what I'm saying. Who wants to live like that? (YouTube, 2016)

Chicago's historical policies and practices on poverty, housing, and gangs backfired and led to the physical and geographical increase in violence still felt across the city today. In 1995, federal law enforcement carried out "Operation Headache" in hopes of dismantling the Chicago Gangster Disciples street gang. Law enforcement officials arrested 22 alleged high-ranking members of the Gangster Disciples street gang in an attempt to take out the higher-level leadership and severely cripple the gang's ability to operate (Ordonez, 1995). The organized demise of the Chicago gang structure, which for over 50 years had provided control of gang members and kept violence from intensifying, was destroyed by Chicago politics. These actions today have resulted in a multiplied number of street gang factions, increased gang membership, and intensified the amount of violence, which has now spread across the city and surrounding suburbs.

The intersection of Chicago's housing policy is rarely included when discussing rates of violence across the city and how housing plays a critical role in the spectrum of violence, particularly during an age of gentrification and a rapidly changing urban environment. Chicago's

political environment, rampant with corruption and racist policy, is at the core of creating an environment ripe for further development of violence and instability across the city.

The demolition of Chicago's housing projects and failure to develop responsible housing policy, resources, access to equal education, and the equal opportunity for a quality of life lie at the heart of understanding how gang culture and violence have become entrenched into the social fabric of Chicago communities. Violence, crime, and murder continue to persist in the Black Belt of Chicago, which continues to consist of the Black Belt neighborhoods, the most socially and economically adversely impacted neighborhoods on the West and South Side of the city.

Parkway Gardens, also known as "O'Block," is a low-income apartment housing development located on the South Side of Chicago at the 6400 block of South Martin Luther King Drive.

O'Block has become a well-known and world-renown neighborhood in Chicago due to recent publicity stemming from constant shoutouts and nods in Chicago drill music culture. O'Block received its infamous name after 20-year-old Odee Perry was murdered in 2011. Gang members memorialized Parkway Gardens as O'Block in tribute to the slain gang member. Odee Perry was allegedly murdered by 17-year-old female gang member Gakirah Barnes also known as "K.I. the Assassin," who lived only one block away from O'Block. Gakirah Barnes was later shot to death not far from her home (Patton, Lane et al., 2017). As of today, the lives of both Odee Perry and Gakirah "K.I." Barnes are constantly noted and referenced in many Chicago drill music songs. No charges were ever filed in either murder and the *Chicago Sun-Times* newspaper named O'Block, the most dangerous block in Chicago (Main, 2014).

Picture on Chicago Crime

Chicago has experienced a stark rise in gun violence since 2016, with murders involving a firearm and taking place in a public setting (University of Chicago Crime Lab, 2017). Violence

in Chicago continues to escalate across the city and is now occurring in settings and neighborhoods that were once deemed to be “safe” or “off-limits”; however, violence in Chicago continues to be disproportionately represented in the most disadvantaged neighborhoods on the South and West Side of Chicago, with these areas also accounting for increased homicide rates. In comparison to other urban cities, the majority of homicides in Chicago involve adolescents, with a large share of the homicide suspects being individuals aged 20 or older (University of Chicago Crime Lab, 2017). More often, victims and suspects involved in gun violence incidents tend to be Black males with some previous involvement in the criminal justice system (University of Chicago Crime Lab, 2017). On a national scale focused on youth in the United States, it is estimated that 38% of youth between the ages of 12-17 witness violence (Zinzow et al., 2009). The constant exposure to community violence or being a victim of violence in youth creates a perpetual sense of indefinitely existing in an environment perceived as threatening, which leads to experiencing a constant sense of anxiety and fear, which permeates into interactions in broader social settings. Unresolved processing of violence exposure at a young age, particularly for Black youth living in adversely impacted communities, can trigger consistent feelings of heightened stress responses and potentially lead to chronic post-traumatic stress disorder (Patton, Sanchez et al., 2017).

Ghetto Corners to Ghattaverse the Immersive Hood Experience

Young adults consistently find spaces to socialize and connect with others. According to Stuart (2020), 45% of teens report “almost constantly” being online, while 89% of teens report online use at least several times daily (Frey, 2018). Smartphones have become the new “bestie” for many individuals, allowing 24/7 access to connect and engage with others. The ability to scroll, like, comment, and post online without boundaries has created a space where individuals

often find the safety to express themselves freely or even take on alternate virtual personas without fear of social repercussions. Social media platforms particularly benefit young adults by allowing them to create virtual hangouts and connecting them with other individuals or virtual communities with related ideals and characteristics.

Black youth are reported to be the highest rate of social media users, with 94% of Black youth from urban communities having at-home access to a smartphone, 79% of Black youth report utilizing YouTube, 77% of Black youth report using Snapchat, and 72% of Black youth report Instagram use; this reflects how deeply intertwined social media are in acting as an indirect vessel for the presentation and consumption of social problems, including gun violence (Frey, 2018). Social media platforms provide individuals with a space in which they can connect with others and express their unfiltered thoughts, views, and experiences with a degree of safety and anonymity. Social media platforms also act as a means for feeling acceptance, validation, and affirmation for one's views, actions, and experiences. This emotional reinforcement also provides individuals with a sense of importance and value and can boost one's self-esteem and perceived online social status or virtual social circle.

The development and evolution of social media over the last 10 years have changed how urban community members connect with each other (Frey, 2018). Black teens account for 10% of daily online content creation compared to White teens. This includes music, videos, and other media sources (Stuart, 2020). The evolution of social media within technology has allowed individuals to reshape, own, and share their narratives within the context of their environment and their self-prescribed social norms (Foster, 2020). A disconnect has long existed between the Black community and news and popular media; experiences and events of importance within the Black community are often not given media coverage or shared on the news. According to Frey

(2018), “Social media allows people to observe and witness social problems others face in more direct and constant ways, including experiences with gun violence” (p. 1). The development of geocoding, Internet cookies, and algorithms allow social media platforms to track and sell an individual’s demographic information, search history, and even location data. As individuals use the Internet and social media platforms on their smartphones, other suggested network interactions are presented based on the user experiences and attachment to physical spaces (Patton, Lane et al., 2017). Internet and social media geo-developers often focus on providing an engaging platform experience for individuals with the financial freedom, accessibility, and capacity to move freely. This practice supports individuals with managing and exploring options for their travel, dining, and leisure experiences (Patton, Lane et al., 2017). These same connectivity practices carried out in cities such as Chicago, with rigid race and class segregation, cause users to experience curtailed mobility in network connections and build the users’ experience around factors including gangs, neighborhood boundaries, and geographical violence (Patton, Lane et al., 2017). According to Patton, Lane et al. (2017), street life heavily influences “the digital street,” affording street-involved individuals a virtual avenue to manage neighborhood and gang rivalries.

Youth from adversely impacted communities are posting online content from cramped apartments, low-income housing, schools, and street corners, all within the ecology of the poverty and violence they experience (Patton et al., 2013). The young Black Chicago experience is often shared and viewed widely on social media; characterized by the drones of people shopping and hanging out at the local corner store, greasy-spoon restaurants lined with bulletproof glass, liquor stores, Currency exchanges, and neighborhoods filled with abandoned properties and/or vacant lots. As young people navigate and cope with the stressors and traumas

within their environment, they often gravitate to their virtual peer community (Patton et al., 2013). The Chicago narrative, which was once controlled by professional media outlets that often ignored, dismissed, and deleted the realities of Black Chicago, has now been revolutionized, reshaped, and retold through the eyes and experiences of young Black Chicago (Foster, 2020). A glimpse into their world, many young Black Chicagoans proudly share these daily realities on social media. The once hidden and unknown young Black Chicago experience is now recorded, liked, shared, and hash-tagged across a global audience.

As Black teens create and consume robust amounts of online content, the quality and focus of their online content are traced by algorithms. These algorithms further embed teens into digital hoods with implications reaching further than neighborhood boundaries. In fact, these cross-sectional engagements often exploit and exacerbate the worst conditions of poverty in Black communities:

During the last two to three decades of the 20th century, Chicago's Black and Latino street gangs transformed themselves from youth groups oriented primarily around identity and social support into corporate-style, outlaw capitalist drug organizations. The shift was fueled by a number of historical factors, most prominent among them the deindustrialization and endemic unemployment, intensifying urban disinvestment, mass incarceration, the crack cocaine epidemic, and growing sense of nihilism amount young people in dispossessed inner-city communities in the face of these realities. (Aspholm, 2020, p. 5)

Street corners have traditionally been the primary source of identifying street gang members and gang activity (Storrod & Densley, 2017). The evolution of technology through web development, smartphones, and social media platforms has revolutionized the faces of gangs and has allowed them to exist in virtual spaces without geographical boundaries. Youth coping with adverse experiences, environmental stressors, and safety concerns often turn to social media platforms to connect with online peers that may live within their community or live in similar high-stress environments. Social media sites have been known to act as a vector of instigating

conflict between individuals and groups, often leading to violent incidents within the physical community environment (Patton, Lane et al., 2017). Though social media has been a medium for instigating conflicts between groups, it also acts as a means for individuals to forge friendships and build a sense of community and safety both online and in real life. As youth navigate community challenges and neighborhood safety, their online community allows them to connect with individuals who may live on the same block or indirectly connect with a “suggested friend.”

Economically disadvantaged neighborhoods located within the South and West Side of Chicago are often known for lacking resources, high crime, and heavy presence of gang culture. Chicago neighborhoods have a long history of gang culture, which has become embedded into the fabric of the identity of many communities. Street-involved individuals who are active in gangs are also very heavily present on social media. Platforms such as Facebook, Snapchat, Instagram, and YouTube are often used as a playground for disrespecting rivals, dissing the dead, and provoking confrontations which often lead to extreme forms of physical and community violence. According to Foster (2020), “Social networking sites have become a catalyst for violence because it is a part of people’s everyday life and their reality” (p. 12).

Millennial gang members exist physically and virtually, both carrying guns and creating Instagram posts. According to Wijeratne et al. (2015), 74% of gang-involved individuals who identify as active gang participants report having an established online presence and being frequent users of the Internet to gain respect for their gang. Gang-involved individuals are now navigating both their physical environment and the virtual hood. Chicago gang culture is deeply intertwined with neighborhood identity and “choosing sides,” so much so that most Chicago youth are introduced to “gang life” at a very early age. Youth participating in normal daily activities such as walking to school or going to the neighborhood park are often confronted with

the Chicago gang culture. Chicago youth often inherit beef and gang affiliation by no choice of their own. This affiliation is often determined or given by others simply based on the block where the individual lives, school they attend, or known familial gang ties. A daily walk to and from school, a harmless game of basketball at the neighborhood court, or a walk to the neighborhood grocery store are often settings in which young Chicagoans, particularly Black males, are confronted and forced to make choices about accepting gang affiliations or making other life or death choices with far-reaching life implications.

In an interview with the Breakfast Club, Chicago drill rapper G-Herbo recounted going home each night:

I remember walking in the house with my gun in my hand, out walking through my momma hallway, all the lights off, the whole hallway door open and my grandmother, I gotta go to her house every day, 'cause I live with my grandmother, but she live in the enemy neighborhood, people trying to kill me on the same block that my grandmother live on. This is my house. I have to go here every night. So, I remember coming from that. You know what I'm saying. Who wants to live like that? (YouTube, 2016)

Individuals who live in communities with high rates of violence have an increased risk of being exposed to violence, joining gangs, or becoming victims of homicide (Patton, Frey et al., 2019).

Redefined Generational Culture

William Julius Wilson transformed public opinion on urban poverty by countering conservative ideals of blaming poverty survivors for their circumstances due to lack of ambition and moral deficiencies. Wilson offered a new theory on poverty, highlighting the decline of the industrial era, lack of gainful employment, and social isolation as being root causes for separating Blacks from the institutions, people, and opportunities needed to achieve success in mainstream society (Stuart, 2020). Wilson highlighted the South Side of Chicago in his work, drawing attention to the demise of American manufacturing, offshoring of blue-collar

employment, and the decline of organized labor unions as being directly connected to urban poverty.

Thirty years later, the once-thriving factory infrastructure of Chicago's South Side has now returned in the form of technology-driven digital platforms, with new profit agenda and far-reaching modes of engagement. Thus, poverty survivors are taking advantage of sharing in the opportunities afforded to the rest of society by taking a place in online media development, challenging the narrative of being unproductive, lazy, and lacking ambition, to share their raw experiences and seizing the opportunity to become tomorrow's next big internet sensation.

According to Kitwana (2003), as generations grow, develop, and transition over time, the cultural identity, values, and norms of those generations are transitioned from one generation to the next. During the 1920s-1960s, much of Black youth culture was derived from traditional values connected to church, schools, and other community institutions. The growth and advancement of technology and corporate growth have significantly impacted the passing of values from those traditional Black institutions. Today, the media, technology, film, and fashion play major roles in transmitting culture from generation to generation (Kitwana, 2003). The new Black youth culture also cuts across previously defined class boundaries and has redefined what it means to be young and Black in America today. Kitwana (2003) suggested that people born between 1965 to 1985 do not belong to Generation X but instead belong to "the hip-hop generation." In this generation, we begin to see a shift away from the previous generations' focus on spirituality, social responsibility, and traditionally defined family units to adopting generational values based on the development and evolution of hip-hop and rap. Kitwana (2003) defined the hip-hop generation as having a generational experience very different from that of their parents and instead adopting a culture based around hip-hop, which was a defining

historical moment for this generation (Patton et al., 2013). The hip-hop generation is a blended generation influenced by previous generational experiences such as the post-civil-rights era and political shifts; however, this generation's worldview was molded by six major sociopolitical phenomena that unfolded during the generation's formative years, the 1980s to 1990s (Kitwana, 2002).

According to Kitwana (2002), the increased visibility of Black youth within popular culture largely contributed to the birth of hip-hop and rap, the emergence of globalization, persistent and contradictory segregation in a nation that prides itself on inclusion, public policy on criminal justice, media representation of Blacks, and the diminished shift in the quality of life for young Blacks. These six major historical experiences during the hip-hop generation's formative years shifted their worldview and created a divide within the previous post-civil-rights generation.

One of the greatest contributions of the hip-hop generation is the birth of rap music. The commercialization of rap music blended seamlessly into what was known as hip-hop and extended its identity. Rap music transcended the once limited scope of hip-hop from being identified as break-dancing, graffiti, rap, and DJ-ing to seeing Black youth street culture being expressed both publicly and privately in fashion, film, beauty, and attitude (Kitwana, 2003). Popular culture took a very dramatic shift in adopting Black culture, and even the visual presence of Black youth within that space demanded a very prominent role. Rap music visually and culturally injected Black youth culture into every facet of popular culture. It is very common now to see Black faces, Black bodies, Black hair, and Black slang included in marketing and advertisement for global companies (Kitwana, 2003). The appearance, style, and language of

youth from places such as Louisiana, Los Angeles, Florida, and Chicago all share the common thread of Black culture, which was not uncoincidentally designed.

The emergence of globalization during the birth of the hip-hop era played a major role in influencing the worldview of the hip-hop generation. According to Kitwana (2002), “Rappers’ access to global media and their use of popular culture to articulate many aspects of this national identity renders rap music central to any discussion of the new Black youth culture” (p. 11). The growth of mega-corporations and globalization further reinforced classism and racism, but in a more subtle fashion. As giant companies have continued to grow, the separation between the haves and the have-nots has become more apparent. The first generation of hip-hop rappers certainly represents an elite group of Black rappers who were able to achieve success and gain access to the resources needed to create opportunity and stability for themselves. This is also true of popular Black athletes such as Magic Johnson and Michael Jordan, who were also able to strike huge deals with global corporations such as Nike and Adidas. College-educated Blacks were also able to achieve higher levels of success and financial stability by pursuing career paths in booming industries. However, this still constitutes a fraction of middle to upper-class members of the Black community. Poor working-class Blacks, primarily males, experienced wage inequality and loss of employment due to the dramatic shift in opportunities and attitudes for less-skilled workers. Globalization shifted many urban-centered manufacturing jobs, which once supported the Black community with growth, to suburban areas and overseas locations (Kitwana, 2002). As unemployment rates continued to rise in the Black community, this directly impacted the next generation’s reliance on the underground street market and drug scene as a means for financial survival.

The presence of overt and subtle segregation in a self-proclaimed “inclusive democratic society” has had a major impact on shifting the worldview of the hip-hop generation and future generations. The parents of the hip-hop generation believed in the power and progress through peaceful demonstration and activism to pursue an equitable quality of life for all. Four decades later, the hip-hop generation and their children have witnessed persistent racism, segregation, and violence against Blacks in real time on a daily basis.

Young Black males continue to experience unemployment at a rate two times that of their White counterparts (Kitwana, 2002). In Chicago, young Blacks experience feelings of hopelessness and concerns about physical safety daily. Violence in Chicago continues to escalate at record numbers, with the city ending 2021 with nearly 800 homicides, a level that has not been seen in 25 years. The West Side community of Austin accounted for the highest number of homicides that occurred in Chicago in 2021 (Rumore, 2022). Violence in Chicago continues to be disproportionately represented in the most disadvantaged neighborhoods on the South and West Side of Chicago.

Young Black Chicagoans experience structural violence and segregation across the city daily. African Americans in Chicago represented 80% of the homicide victims in 2016, with the majority being males between ages 15 and 34 (University of Chicago, 2016). Blacks continue to struggle to win political seats and have representation in state and federal government roles. In a post-civil-rights, post-Barack-Obama era, young Blacks have seen little progress that would encourage them to subscribe to the ideals and beliefs of previous generations. Statues of White Confederate generals still stand in many cities, and many Black neighborhoods, schools, and parks in Black communities are named after known White racist enslavers. These are examples

of double standards and lip service that breed resentment among Black youth culture in what is presented as an inclusive democratic society with opportunity for all.

Criminal justice policy and the “War on Drugs” played a significant role in shifting the worldview of the hip-hop generation and future generations. In 1992, political policy enacted to punish drug crimes rather than rehabilitate, combined with the disparity in criminal justice sentencing for crack cocaine versus powder cocaine, had a huge impact on the hip-hop generation. An offender found to have as little as five grams of crack cocaine, a form of the compound heavily present in the Black community, would receive a sentence 100 times greater than an offender found to have the same amount in powder cocaine, which is more prevalent in White communities, with no difference in the chemical makeup, the only difference being the affordability of crack cocaine (Kitwana, 2002). In 1992, Chicago enacted anti-gang/anti-drug law enforcement tactics, prohibiting two or more youths from congregating in public areas like the walkway in front of their homes or public parks (Kitwana, 2002). These anti-youth ordinances disguised as the city taking a tough stance on crime by enacting harsh public safety measures led to the arrest of nearly 40,000 young adults within a two-year period. Chicago law enforcement efforts went as far as developing a “gang database” with photos and contact data on any suspected gang member. The Chicago Crime Commission (2012) released a Chicago “Gang Book,” which consisted of the names and photographs of hundreds of suspected gang member, their family members, and other associates. This information was distributed widely, with much of the information being false and erroneous. Today’s generation of Black youth culture witnesses police brutality and homicide against Black lives in real time; LaQuan McDonald, George Floyd, and Duante Wright’s murders at the hands of police were broadcast worldwide in

viral videos. The young Black experience of violence, racial profiling, injustice, and inequality is played out around the clock and accessible with a click or scroll on a smartphone.

Representation of Blacks in media was uncommon prior to the mainstream explosion of hip-hop and rap. Blacks were most widely seen in media on the nightly news, with young Black males often dehumanized. Media coverage of crimes committed by Blacks was reported in a much more heinous and monstrous comparison to Whites committing the same types of crimes. This type of constant negative portrayal of Black youth contributed to alienating young Blacks from mainstream media (Kitwana, 2002).

The shift in the quality of life for Blacks has also significantly shifted the Black youth culture generational worldview. Since the 1980s, many young Blacks continue to live at or below the poverty level. It is estimated that 60% of poor youth in America are Black (Kitwana, 2002). According to the 2019 report on youth unemployment in Chicago, inclusive of women, 37% of Black Chicago young adults do not have a job or attend school. Compared to their White counterparts benefiting from the privilege of family wealth, investment, property ownership, and not battling racism, report 5.7% of young adults aged 20-24 are out of school and/or work daily. In comparison, young Black men and women fare worse than the 24% reported by other young people across the country (Mulaikal & Issa, 2019). Chicago's defined "Black Belt" continues to place the city as the most segregated for housing and quality education in the United States.

The response to these generationally historic events has been minimal. Awareness and discussion around these issues have been nonexistent. Kitwana (2002) stated that much of this is due to internal strife within the Black community, with the older post-civil-rights generation and hip-hop generation being at odds. Parents and grandparents of hip-hop generation children find many new aspects of Black youth culture behavior embarrassing to the race (Kitwana, 2002).

Images of thousands of young Blacks converging in party and dance in Atlanta, while the Black church continues to see a decline in engagement and attendance from young Blacks, continues to harbor a long-lasting disconnect between the generations (Kitwana, 2002). Rap music itself is often dismissed by the older generation and written off as lacking intelligence, meaning, and comprehensibility. Rap music for the hip-hop generation and beyond has been the most important and notable accomplishment of the generation.

As the young Black generation continues to refine, develop, and solidify the genre of rap and hip-hop's place in American culture, generational values in Black youth culture continue to reflect but strategically shift away from the ideals of previous generations. This shift is demonstrated today in areas such as activism, where currently, in the technology age, we see Black athletes, Black artists, and Black media take a very public stance on race and political issues without the fear of expressing disagreement with entities such as large corporations, political officials, and even prominent civil rights activist.

As time has passed and the nexus from which generational values are passed has changed over the past four decades, social norms, technology, and ideals on class and race have continued to shift. The unresolved historical incidents impacting the hip-hop generation have continued to shape and mold generational values for new Black youth culture. For decades, the characterization and dehumanization of the Black male have existed. We see a shift and reinforcement of the dangerous, super-predatory, thug ideology reinforced and defined in popular media. The assassination of the character of young Black males has occurred for decades. Black males have been dehumanized and characterized with stereotypes such as uneducated, criminal, drug dealer, and lazy; with the new "Millennial" generation, we begin to see a radical embracement and acceptance of this identity. As a result, the decades of molding

the identity of what it means to be a young Black male haVE morphed into the creation and acceptance of the young Black “super-predator.” If society defines and characterizes me as a thug, I will become the ultimate “super-predator.” If society defines me as a violent thug, I will aggressively demonstrate that if society identifies me as a person who will rob and steal, then I will take; I will become their worst nightmare.

Kitwana (2002) concluded that due to significant historical events that have taken place over the past four decades, the perception and result of those events have contributed to setting the stage for criminalizing urban American males. Over the years, it has become necessary for urban males to adapt and accept their perceived characterization in a post-civil-rights era. Rap and hip-hop are often perceived as having a dominant, rebellious tone that speaks for Black males. This perception can be received as being antagonistic to Western culture. Rap music, in many ways, has rejected the mainstream norms of the predominant White culture and instead embraced opposing values. In combination with poverty, unemployment, educational opportunity gaps, and targeted mass incarceration, this dichotomy has acted as a significant driver in influencing the persona, behavior, and character of Black males currently seen in drill music culture (Kitwana, 2002). The highly visual and influential nature of music and social media allow these mediums to act as vessels for this behavior to be replicated in an ongoing manner. The alienation and dehumanization of the Black lives in mainstream society projects a demoralizing and debilitating undertone that is consistently played out publicly through social media and viral videos. The consistent environmental factors and public characterization of Black youth leave this group struggling with complex issues related to their development and identity. As Black youth begin to grow into their identity, music, social media, and environmental factors play a huge role in their characterization of self. In today’s society, music

and social media are the voice of youth across America. Youth are now able to communicate their innermost thoughts and feelings to each other and the world using hashtags, memes, and emojis. Through this mode of communication, youth receive attention, concern, and validation. In a society that has alienated and exiled Black youth, music and social media act as a primary means for them to be seen, heard, and felt by mainstream society.

In Chicago particularly, drill music culture has provided young Black Chicago with a means to command the attention of the world, visually through the shock and awe of displaying the poverty, guns, and violence experienced by this group, but also audibly through raw, unfiltered musical storytelling, shared with an undertone of survival and vengeance. Drill music culture and social media have provided many Black Chicago with a sense of distorted love, dysfunctional recognition, stardom, and an accessible and viable means out of the “trenches.” Reactionary masculine behavior by Black males in social media is welcomed and applauded (Kitwana, 2002). Rap artists are expected to always “be on,” displaying the tough, no-nonsense, hood G-code expectations. This behavioral pathology gains the likes, shares, applauds, and attention of the mainstream audience and increases opportunities for financial gain. Rappers across the hip-hop genre are expected to build their career and audience appeal by always keeping it real (Kitwana, 2002).

Historically, rappers have gained their credibility and audience by holding true to their rough, “keep it real” approach, demonstrated through their music and videos. Rapper Curtis “50 Cent” Jackson was discovered and introduced to the industry by way of famed producer and rapper Dr. Dre. 50 Cent established credibility for his debut album, *Get Rich or Die Trying*, by sharing his real-life backstory through interviews and film about his life. 50 Cent shared his experience of being a gang-affiliated individual, well-known in the street/drug economy. 50 Cent

even shared that his mother was well-known in the street economy and had introduced him to the lifestyle. 50 Cent also became well known for having been shot nine times in various areas all over his body, including in his mouth, causing his somewhat slurred speech. The album, movie, and demonstrated realness and authenticity of 50 Cent gave him the credibility that helped catapult him into the spotlight in the early 2000s. 50 Cent later became enthralled in a beef with popular rapper Ja Rule, at which time 50 Cent released the song “Wanksta” which mocked Ja Rule and accused him of being a gangster “wanna-be.” This song became widely known and became 50 Cent’s first hit single to peak at number 13 on the Billboard chart (O’Connor, 2018).

Black Culture in Music and Media

Hip-hop street credibility was once gained by an artist’s public persona, an edgy name, and perhaps an interesting backstory. Prior to the hip-hop culture’s ability to post videos on social media platforms, World Star Hip-Hop (WSHH) accounted for a significant convergence of hip-hop/rap, urban artist authenticity, and viral video. WSHH gained popularity in its introductory years as a music downloading site, allowing signed and independent artists to promote their albums and mixtapes. The popularity of WSHH soon exploded, and the site became a gem in the Black community for its distinct representation of blackness (Foster, 2020). WSHH continued to grow as a popular source for online video aggregation as WSHH began to post and share individuals filming street fights, often of Black community members recording and fighting each other while yelling out “World Star.” The phenomenon became very popular in Black culture, and soon people all over the country were seen pulling out cell phones to record and post viral videos. WSHH soon became the premier source for finding the latest mixtape drops, personal artist interviews/interactions, and Black viral videos that were not found or shared in mainstream media. WSHH played a significant role in perpetuating and soliciting

stereotypes of Blacks as being loud and aggressive (Foster, 2020). WSHH soon became a proxy for new and established rappers to promote their street persona and gain credibility with their audience.

According to Patton et al. (2013), “Hip-hop once served as a proxy for street credibility, but recently new social media has taken its place as the medium through which street credibility is established and disseminated” (p. 55). In 2009, rapper Rick Ross became engaged in a public multi-state conflict with the Gangster Disciples, which played out over social media networking sites. Ross alleged that his rap career started with the backstory of a drug dealer turned rapper until his rap persona was exposed as fake due to images circulating of him working as a correctional officer in a jail (Patton et al., 2013). Members of the Gangster Disciples were displeased with Ross’ fake persona and musical references to the gang’s leader. Videos of Gangster Disciple gang members across several states were soon uploaded to YouTube, threatening the rapper’s life, causing Ross to cancel multiple shows.

Emergence of Chicago Drill Music

Chicago drill rappers are expected to demonstrate an even higher level of “savage” behavior to live up to the glory, clout, and credibility of being known as ex-offenders, high-ranking gang members, shooters, and demons. The longstanding beef between Chicago Gangster Disciples and Black Gangster Disciples has been a historic gang war that has carried on in the Black community for decades. This well-known beef is constantly referenced in drill music culture lyrics, threats dissing the dead, and “keeping the score” of the number of individuals who have been killed from the opposing side. This well-known Chicago gang war has fueled much of Chicago drill music culture and given credibility to the artist and their affiliated gang for their audience. This is a turn away from hip-hop and rap’s traditional method of settling beefs through

rap battles and creative diss tracks and further established the credibility of drill rappers and their affiliates by engaging in real-life behind the music violence, which has often led to extreme harm and/or murder. Rap battles and public truces between mainstream industry artists such as Jay-Z and Nas or Kanye West and Drake were acceptable hip-hop beefs that mainstream media could swallow, but for new artists with an established social media audience, publicly known gang affiliations, a public criminal background, and reputation for violent and vicious behavior, rap battles and truces represent an elitist and watered-down version of rap that does not connect with the young Black Chicago experience. In a city plagued by poverty, violence, and homicide, many young Blacks who take pride in their name recognition, hood, and gang affiliation entered the rap genre by storm, reflecting their young Black Chicago experience and true stories of life and survival in the Windy City.

In September 2012, 18-year-old rapper Joseph Coleman, often known by his stage name “Lil JoJo,” was shot in the back and killed as he rode his bicycle through the Englewood neighborhood in Chicago. JoJo had watched the growing popularity of 16-year-old Chicago drill rapper Chief Keef and JoJo recently began creating songs and posting videos to social media in an attempt to recreate the East Coast versus West Coast rap battle between rappers Notorious B.I.G. and Tupac Shakur. JoJo was an alleged member of the Chicago Gangster Disciples street gang and began posting videos to social media and YouTube entitled “3HunnaK,” adding the letter “K” to reference “Killer,” a play on the title of Chief Keef’s alleged homage to the rival Black Disciples. The video postings of JoJo show an extremely young-looking teenager and his friends waving numerous firearms to the song, including a Tech 9 and an AK 47. According to Chicago police, JoJo’s killing may have been connected to the longstanding beef between the Gangster Disciples and Black Disciples street gangs. It was reported that JoJo had been engaged

in an online feud with members of the 300 factions of the Black Disciples street gang prior to the shooting. A few hours following JoJo's death, Chicago drill rapper Chief Keef tweeted, "Its Sad Cuz Dat Nigga JoJo Wanted To Be Jus Like Us [#LMAO](#)" @Glory Boy, Chief Keef" 1:24 AM · Sep 5, 2012 · Twitter Web Client. Keef later stated that his account had been hacked.

The rivalry between Lil JoJo and Chief Keef had gone on publicly for months prior to JoJo's murder. Both JoJo and Keef had uploaded taunting music videos to YouTube, later shared on WSHH. The two were making threats against each other, displaying firearms, and chanting their gang affiliations (Foster, 2020). The last video uploaded by Lil JoJo showed him driving into rival gang territory, confronting Chicago drill rapper and Chief Keef associate Lil Reese, yelling at Reese that he would kill him. Incidents that started online and resulted in real-life violence and murder have become a new trend in social media (Patton et al., 2013). Hip-hop, violence, gangs, and the Internet have become interconnected, and this union has acted as a means for exposing and exacerbating violence in urban settings while also escalating and normalizing violence, particularly for young Black Chicago.

The New Chicago Wave

*I'm cooling wit my youngins
And what we smoke one hunna
But nigga I'm three hunna
Click clack, pow, now he running
Don't be fucking with my youngins
Them niggas be drumming
They take your ass down, shit, we need them bricks or something
Keep this shit one hunna
I keep this shit three hunna*

At the age of 16, Keith Cortez (stage name "Chief Keef") shocked the world with his raw, gritty style of Chicago drill rap and low-budget videos featuring Keef and his shirtless peers chanting gang affiliations and gesturing as if aiming guns into the camera. Chief Keef gained the

world's attention from the confines of his bedroom while on house arrest at his grandmother's home in the Englewood community located on the Souths Side of Chicago. At the time, Chief Keef was a relatively unknown teenage Chicago artist with fewer than 2,000 followers on his Twitter account @Glory_Boy. Keef was an alleged member of a Chicago street gang, which splintered off and formed Glory Boyz Entertainment (Stuart, 2020). As a street-based gang /entertainment group, Keef and his peers gained local recognition among other street-affiliated members and the local high school-aged population. Keef also gained notoriety for his criminal background, including a well-publicized arrest for firing a weapon at Chicago police officers (Stuart, 2020). As Keef's street infamy increased, so did his fanbase.

Keef soon gained popularity among Chicago's high-school-aged population and was known for uploading free music, mixtapes, and videos on YouTube and other free music streaming platforms for new independent artists. Keef's breakout song "Bang" has garnered over 15 million views on YouTube. Keef and his peer-released music and mixtapes focused mainly on rapping about local events happening in Chicago and ongoing rivalries happening on Chicago blocks by fragmented gang factions and the challenges, police interaction, and other experiences related to everyday life as a young Black Chicagoans. Chief Keef soon released the local underground hit "I Don't Like," which drew the attention of Kanye West, gained mainstream popularity, and currently has 44 million views on YouTube. The lyrics of Keef's song highlight loyalty to the gang, loyalty to the street code of justice, and disgust for "snitches," individuals involved in criminal investigations and provide incriminating evidence against others to negotiate a better outcome for themselves. The release of Keef's song and video played a key role in breaking a barrier for Chicago drill music artists and redefined the formula for "making it" in the mainstream recording industry (Stuart, 2020). Keef's raw, gritty videos, infamous street

reputation, and established young social media following made him a hot commodity. Instead of Keef independently selling CDs on street corners in hopes to vie for the attention of a major record label for an exploitive contract, Keef had major record labels seeking him out and bidding for him to join their team. Keef's song "I Don't Like" became a battle cry anthem for Chicago streets and demonstrated to other Chicago youth in similar positions as Keef that even without the investment from a large record label, with simple smartphone apps to create beats and a small video budget, Chicago youth could still gain access and have a voice in mainstream society. The more street credibility Keef gained from the public nature of his criminal cases, the larger his success and audience continued to grow, finally landing Keef a six-million-dollar contract with Interscope records. Many of Keef's friends and affiliates featured in his songs and videos had also released music and grabbed international attention (Stuart, 2020). Another group of teens from the East Side of Chicago formed a gang/drill music group called "No Limit Muskegon Boyz and Never Leave My Brother," which garnered industry attention. Members G-Herbo and Lil Bibby went on to be signed by major labels and appear in a plethora of mainstream music and videos. The authenticity of the music and stories shared by Chicago drill artists such as Chief Keef, Lil Durk, G-Herbo, King Von, and many other Chicago drillers commanded the attention, credibility, and investment of the mainstream media while also creating a path for themselves out of the poverty and violence they experienced in Chicago.

Social media and music have become everyday essentials in the lives of youth today. Most Chicago drill music artists, born and raised in marginalized communities, have lived a background that is indistinguishable from what many other young Black people living in Chicago have experienced (Stuart, 2020). These pioneer Chicago drill artists created a form of musical expression that authentically reflected their young Black Chicago experience in a way

that commanded the attention of the world. The ingenuity of their social media presence and self-branding strategies supported them in gaining a huge following while allowing them to “backdoor” the mainstream music industry. According to Patton et al. (2013), “For decades, many Chicago neighborhoods have been steeped in gang culture, resulting in turf conflict and entrenched gang-related violence that has become weaved into the social fabric of communities” (p. 58). For other members of young Black Chicago, drill music culture is a movement that represents the experiences and voice of the new generation in rap. The strategies these artists used were their stories, along with free to low-cost technology resources, and items attainable to other young Blacks living in Chicago and beyond. The Chicago drill culture movement has gone on to influence other young Black community members, often operating in survival mode to join the wave.

Chicago’s drill music culture’s raw, gritty, violent nature is a unique blend of redefined generational values, poverty survival, normalized violence, street involvement, and technology. Chicago drill music culture creates a space that lives outside of the boundaries of commercialized mainstream rap and its dependence on large record labels, and turns away the traditional glorification of luxurious cars and homes that are often touted in traditional rap videos and instead celebrates the adverse neighborhoods, street affiliations and, violence that have literally impacted the artists’ ability to survive. Chicago drill music embraces the concepts of being “hood famous,” having widely shared loyal gang affiliations, and being willing to carry out violent acts as a means for survival and/or revenge. Chicago drill music allows the new Black youth generation an independent voice in which they can meet their identified needs by sharing their story and creating their sound on their own terms.

Historically, Blacks have been represented in mainstream media as loud, ignorant, and violent (Foster, 2020). The complex relationship between Black identity, hip-hop culture, and social media has become an area of extreme interest. Black community members' use of social media has allowed the community a tool for self-expression, which exposes the realities Blacks experience while living in America. The raw expressions shared on social media have also contributed to the criminalization and dehumanization of the Black community (Foster, 2020). Poverty, violence, and gangs continue to represent a significant challenge for cities like Chicago. However, social media use and music by the new young Black Chicago generation have intensified violence and highlighted the complex connections between real-life and digital street life. Therefore, processing the complex critical issues of poverty, violence, and the young Black experience requires major cities like Chicago to analyze and understand more than statistics on crime data, but to also recognize the impact of the young Black experience of segregation, poverty, and violence shared through music and digital culture.

CHAPTER THREE: METHODOLOGY

Design

The qualitative method utilized in this study focused on understanding how environmental factors and life experiences of young Black Chicago impact and connect to the relationships community members have with Chicago drill music culture. This research study used grounded theory to create meaning in the relationships young Black Chicagoans have with Chicago drill music culture and how environmental factors and experiences impact the relationship. This study is of interest in theorizing that Chicago drill music culture provides a lens through which young Black Chicago residents can connect to interpret their environment and experiences. Also, the constant exposure to Chicago street-based culture, violent crime, and social media leads to a heightened survival response mentality. This study used a combination of song elicitation, personal experiences, and lyric elicitation to understand the participants' experiences, perceptions, and beliefs. This study used the participants' recounting of background and experiences along with impactful songs and lyrics to solicit data. This study highlighted how participants responded to processing their Black Chicago experiences after recalling Chicago drill music songs and lyrics to determine the degree of connection and impact.

Theoretical Framework

This research study formed a theory by analyzing the data provided by participants using a grounded theory approach. The study used informal, semi-structured interviews and Chicago drill music song elicitation. Data were collected by writing, recording notes, and utilizing coding. The grounded theory framework supported understanding of how young Black Chicagoans interpret and process their personal experiences through the lens of Chicago drill music. This research studied how young Black Chicago community members make meaning of their

environment, experiences, and community behavior. This research study used the grounded theory approach and music elicitation to find overlap and relationships between the young Black Chicago experience and Chicago drill music culture.

Participants

The number of interview participants was 11, with 8 male-identified participants and 3 female-identified participants. All study participants identified as Chicago drill music content creators or frequent listeners of Chicago drill music, defined as listening to Chicago drill music five or more times per week. Study participants ranged in age from 21-45, with 73% of participants ranging from 21 to 35. All study participants identified as Black residents in the city of Chicago with communities of origin on the South and West Side of the city. Study participants identified as being from the Woodlawn, Chatham, East Washington Park, South Deering, Lawndale, and Austin communities. Two study participants identified as experiencing unstable housing and moving around many South Side Chicago communities.

Procedure

All study participants were recruited through purposeful sampling. Open invitations regarding the research study were advertised through flyers, phone calls, email, and virtual posts on Facebook, Instagram, and LinkedIn. The criteria for participation in one-on-one interviews required that the participant be age 18 or over, a Chicago resident, and create or frequently listen to Chicago drill music content.

Each research participant met with the interviewer on one occasion, which lasted 60-90 minutes. The researcher met participants in person at a location of the participant's choice, which allowed the participant to feel most comfortable. Each interview was conducted in a semi-

structured format, using preplanned, open-ended questions to allow for the introduction of additional follow-up questions to assist with gaining further insight from the participant.

All interviews were audio-recorded using the Otter.ai software. Each interview began with questions regarding the participant's definition of Chicago drill music, along with song and drill music artist elicitation. Participants were asked to share the most memorable or powerful Chicago drill music song they could recall and why that song was personally impactful. Participants were also asked to identify their favorite Chicago drill music artist and share why the participant connected with the artist. The purpose behind opening the interview in this format allowed the researcher to begin to develop rapport with the participant and supported the researcher in gaining a deeper understanding of the participant's specific connection to a particular Chicago drill song and Chicago drill artist.

Informed consent was obtained from each participant and gained through safe instruments agreed upon by the participants. Each participant was provided an informed consent form and asked to review the entire document. The researcher also provided each participant a verbal summary of each section covered in the informed consent and allowed time for the participant to ask questions or share concerns. All participants were given the opportunity to ask questions or opt-out prior to beginning the interview. The informed consent form explicitly provided participants with the opportunity to opt-out of the study at any time or refuse to answer any question the participant did not feel comfortable with answering. All participants were given the option to use an alias during the interview to keep the participants' identities anonymous. Participants were asked to provide responses to interview questions and informed that they should feel free to elaborate or decline to answer any question at their level of comfort.

Participants were offered a \$25 gift card to participate in the study and informed they would receive the gift card regardless of completing or discontinuing participation in the study.

Instrumentation

Each interview opened with the participant defining and describing Chicago drill music in their own words. Participants were also asked to identify their favorite Chicago drill music artist and the most power Chicago drill song with the most personal impact. Participants were also asked to talk about why they connected with the artist and song they identified. Participants were then asked to discuss their thoughts on Chicago drill music in comparison to other genres of rap/hip-hop.

Having the participant define and describe Chicago drill music and identifying specific artists and songs that felt meaningful to the participant allowed the participant to define and narrate their interpretation. The questions helped understand the participants' interpretations of Chicago drill music while defining how specific artists and songs connected with the participants' personal experiences, attitudes, and beliefs. The interviews consisted of additional questions that gauged the participants' personal experiences to understand conscious connections to Chicago drill music.

Coding

Analyzing the qualitative data from each interview was done in several stages. The initial stage of data analysis was conducted utilizing open coding. This data analysis strategy allowed content from each interview to be segmented into discrete thoughts and expressions. This data analysis stage allowed the identification of overarching repeating concepts and codes. The second data analysis stage was axial coding. This data analysis stage was used to understand connections, relationships, and patterns between the codes developed during the open coding

stage. The codes were then grouped into categories and emerging themes. The final stage of data analysis used was selective coding. During this stage, categories developed during selective coding were connected around one core category. The core category methodically validated and related to other categories while identifying categories for further development.

CHAPTER FOUR: RESULTS

Research Goals

The following were the research goals in this study:

- To better understand why the young Black Chicago community members create and listen to Chicago drill music.
- To better understand how Chicago drill music is perceived and interpreted by young Black Chicago.
- To determine how the community members of young Black Chicago interpret their lived experiences through the lens of Chicago drill music.

Research data were analyzed using the focused analysis technique. The focused analysis process revealed several common themes referenced throughout participants' interviews. This included participants' recollections of formative, adolescent, and adult experiences occurring while living in Chicago, which provided insight and understanding of their perceptions of Chicago drill music and the relationship with young Black Chicago. Participants shared their household background, experiences, details on family and friends, real-life experiences and events, and real-life situations and challenges related to their connection to listening to or creating Chicago drill music. The research questions were designed to provide deeper insight into understanding the strengths, environmental factors, supports, and challenges of the young Black Chicago community. The guiding concept was to understand the development and popularity of Chicago drill music while increasing awareness and changing the narrative around the contributing factors supporting the connections between young Black Chicago community members.

The participant data unveiled two overarching themes that produced several subthemes, and within the subthemes that were discussed, several were discussed more often than others. Participant interviews revealed meaningful quotes connected to themes and were used as examples of the experiential connection to the overarching themes. The primary overarching themes of shared experience and validation were identified through participants sharing stories based on their engagement in Chicago drill music culture, relating to the participants' individual experiences and community perspectives and the commonness and frequency of the events and situations young Black Chicago community members consistently navigate. These experiences led to the development of the overarching themes, which uncovered the four subthemes: Chicago gang culture, grief and loss, vigilance, clout, and resilience. The interconnection between these themes demonstrated an association and relationship to each other. Shared experience connected to language/communication style, violence, neighborhood environmental factors, and negative interactions with police were major factors that allowed participants to relate to Chicago drill music artists and songs. Grief and loss, validation, Chicago gang culture, vigilance, clout, and resilience were ways in which participants made sense of their individual and community experiences related to Chicago drill music. One of the many mental health and wellness factors discussed by participants was grief and loss. Participants discussed the emotional discourse associated with living or frequenting Chicago's underserved communities bearing witness to community issues such as addiction, gangs, chronic violence, death, and murder. Shared experience was interconnected to grief and loss because of the commonality of experiencing the loss of family and/or friends to murder. Nearly all participants highlighted experiencing the loss of a relative or close friend to murder, and the recurring pain, confusion, anger, and numbness felt with the news of a new loss. Murder, death, and shootings have become a part of expected

normal everyday life events for young Black Chicago, no different than waking up every day and having breakfast. Murder, death, and retaliation have become so common that details of shootings and deaths have now become intertwined in Chicago drill music songs and used to taunt, instigate, and unleash psychological pain on opposing groups. Participants noted that this is a tactic often used by rival gang-affiliated cliques and shared through social media and music. Participants highlighted the problematic nature of this type of behavior and did not condone it being used in Chicago drill music. However, participants believed this form of “entertainment” is what made individuals and artists popular or known in the street or desirable individuals to gain financial success through social media and/or mainstream record labels.

Despite the references to murder, death, and taunting lyrics used in Chicago drill music to disrespect individuals who had died, participants viewed Chicago drill music as a normal form of creative expression and entertainment, no different than any other category of hip-hop or rap content. Participants regarded Chicago drill rap as a way in which information is shared, and stories are told to discuss the details of the common everyday occurrences happening across many Black communities in Chicago. The majority of participants connected to a Chicago drill song or artist because the realities discussed in the music were comparable to their everyday life experiences. Some participants identified as having been gang-involved or gang-affiliated at some point during their teenage or adult years. All participants recognized the interconnection between Chicago drill music and Chicago gangs; however, the participants highlighted the metamorphosis of Chicago gangs from once structured organizations into the present day nearly unavoidable disjointed gang cliques present across most Chicago neighborhoods. Shared experience was connected to Chicago gang culture due to the frequent and routine nature of the interactions and crossroad experiences young Black Chicago community members have related

to gang-related experiences. Validation connected to the abovementioned themes because each participant expressed the authenticity in their daily life experiences with much of the lyrical content included in Chicago drill music. Participants highlighted the need to create awareness around the issues impacting young Black Chicago community members face daily. Participants expressed that the narrative of young Black Chicago is dismissed or inaccurately reported in local media and political reports. Participants expressed that Chicago drill music provides a real look at Chicago through the eyes of the community members who are often mischaracterized and demonized in the public and political landscape. Chicago drill music offers a raw, unfiltered perspective of the realities facing young Black Chicago. Participants referenced Chicago drill music as a voice that provides a self-narrated perspective of the harsh truths of life in Chicago from a young Black perspective. Vigilance was interconnected to Chicago gang culture due to the constant hyperawareness participants expressed related to being aware of the neighborhood, surroundings, and constant need to assess risk and safety while carrying out normal daily activities. Chicago drill music has played a significant role in reporting events happening within the young Black Chicago community. This information allowed participants to be informed of areas that pose significant safety issues or high-risk behaviors and activities to avoid. Clout connected to the above-noted themes. As young Black Chicago community members engage in the various settings in their environment, they often find the need to posture to create an appearance of toughness. Young Black Chicago community members often promote this outward persona of toughness through their social media presence and the reputation promoted through Chicago drill music; these behaviors often allow young Black Chicago community members to become “known” for their fearless behavior and can deter threatening behaviors from other individuals or groups. Resilience was interconnected to clout due to the opportunities

to gain notoriety and publicity in pursuit of financial gain and a way to “make it out” to a better quality of life. All participants were asked abstract questions, which provided insight into their experiences, attitudes, and beliefs. Participants often shared their thoughts and provided an experience-based scenario that explained the participants’ responses. An example question and response might read:

Tell me, in your own words, how you would describe Chicago drill music? If I could explain what drill music is in my own words, I would say it is just a depiction. A word depiction from the artists um of their events, their lives, I mean in the blunt most black and white form you can get it, you know, from the trauma the pain, the reality, and so on.

Through these open-ended questions, the researcher was able to gain insight into the participants’ views while gaining an understanding of the participants’ life experiences that connected with their views on Chicago drill music. This approach allowed the participant to speak about their personal lived experiences related to Chicago drill music songs, lyrics, and artists.

Data Analysis

The data collected from participant interviews unveiled six major themes and several subthemes. The themes were developed by analyzing participant responses to questions specifically focused on Chicago drill music songs, lyrics, artists, and questions geared toward understanding the participants’ life experiences in Chicago. The major themes and subthemes were developed through open-ended questions, song elicitation, and lived experiences. Participant responses varied when asked to define Chicago drill music. Some participants referenced Chicago drill music as a source of reporting on incidents happening in many Chicago neighborhoods; however, many participants responded by describing Chicago drill music as a means that captured the overall experience and realities of the young Black Chicago experience. As participants provided more detail about their daily life experiences in Chicago, it provided

insight into how Chicago drill music captures these experiences and connects to the young Black Chicago audience. The majority of participants spoke about their involvement in Chicago drill music culture as an artist, content creator, or frequent listener and described the elements of Chicago drill music that connected to their personal stories. The six subthemes were derived from the stories of personal experience, and participants identified drill song elicitation.

Themes

Shared Experience

Chicago has often played an understated role in the world of rap and hip-hop, despite having a heavy influence on the sound, language, dance, and overall style. Each participant was asked to define Chicago drill music, and each response suggested that Chicago drill music gives a raw, unfiltered, realistic picture of common events and experiences happening across many Chicago neighborhoods:

I remember my boy like, “Nah, you need to listen to this. This where we at. This the real stuff we going through. This the stuff we living through even though they out South with it,” and then that’s when they went on. (name, personal communication, February 18, 2022)

Participants discussed how the shocking stories told in many Chicago drill songs are relevant to their lives in some way and how these real stories and experiences are often reflected or covered in local news media or the stories are inaccurately reported. Each participant discussed how Chicago drill music provides an underground vantage and context for common occurrences young Black Chicagoans experience regularly.

In many interviews, participants referenced Chicago’s historical discriminatory treatment of Blacks in housing, policing, education, employment, and neighborhood investment. “Drill music, we will say that the founding factors of drill music is oppression” (personal communication, September 10, 2021). The environmental factors and the consequences of the

apparent disinvestment in Chicago neighborhoods on the South and West Side were a common denominator referenced by participants:

We just have like a lot of overlapping factors. The most violent police force in the whole country, per the Federal Bureau of Investigation. We we've got all of these people, right, the third-largest population, but less actual jobs for all these people. Almost half of our population is Black, yet, we have majority Black filled penitentiary. So, you just got all these overlapping factors that just points to like, "Hey, y'all have to figure it out." and the "y'all" being, the younger generation of the time, like "y'all" have just got to create a new way. Create a new way to survive. (name, personal communication, January 25, 2022)

Participants described their personal experiences and reflected on their formative and adolescent years, with many highlighting their experiences living in the Chicago housing projects and subsequent displacement into poor Chicago communities on the South and West Side:

The appearance was just like, Night of the Living Dead, you know how you got people walking around like, that how it was just a whole bunch of . . . we just called them hypes, crack heads and dope fiends, but that was the word for them hypes. So, it was just run down raggedy unkept. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

The impact of the crack epidemic and "War on Drugs," in Chicago, combined with rising unemployment, gang violence, and negative police interactions, expose the young Black Chicago community to constant interactions with violence, death, and murder. Participants shared their connection to these issues and how they continually navigate and adjust their lives around these issues daily. "When I turned the corner, abandoned buildings everywhere, dope lines all the way down the street, cocaine lines all the way around the corner, right, and you speak of what your environment entails" (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021).

When asked to define Chicago drill music, participants described it as a homegrown sound and culmination of real or potentially imminent events detailing the reality and experiences of young Black Chicago. Many participants described Chicago drill songs as being the "hood news":

If I could explain what drill music is in my own words, I would say it is just a depiction. A word depiction from the artists um of their events their lives, I mean in the blunt most Black and White form you can get it, you know, from the trauma the pain, the reality, and so on. So, I think it's just a totally accurate account of their current events in music. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

The harsh reality of what they're actually spitting, you know, singing, speaking, rhyming, is so real, obviously because we see it every day. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

The segregation, I think, really played a big part in it, especially when all the projects was up. You know what I'm sayin' you got all these folks in these projects and these little pockets. And it's high-rises to the 20 something floor or whatever, however many floors it is per person. And you got thousands upon thousands of people living in them. And so much drugs that don't even make no sense. And then the gangs are running, obviously, the enterprises to. . . . So, you know I'm saying protect they turf and whatever man so, you know, it was just, I think the segregation really played a big part to sum it up though. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

It gave those little kids who was in front of the TV, looking at SpongeBob and playing Call of Duty and the games, a voice of their pain like this is what we live through. And I'm outside. I'm 13 years old. They just killed my homie who 13, and we call it a block. We done named the block after him now, in his memory, but it's 14 of us that hang together, and we got 20 something guns. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

Drill music was actually like the inside reporter. It became like the reporter, y'all not going in there Channel 5 and all them, no they be on the outskirts this is Tom Brokaw or whatever, you know that people got their names right. But in the hood, you had a fanboy, he was a reporter, you know, he reporting, I was right there when they came through, and they have a chopper which is an AK 47, And you know I'm saying, and shooting and they came around, and they found 125 shell cases damn 125 shell cases AK 47 shells and AR-15, so these shorties actually became reporters on the block. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

I would describe it as Chicago. That's it! You just can't . . . don't give it . . . it's Chicago! Because every, every aspect of Chicago is in there, the grittiness, the story, its mixed, its everything mixed in. (name, personal communication, November 28, 2021)

I'm here in the city, I know what's going on, I know a lot of people stories, and I can relate. . . . and I know the truth versus the lies, and it's like music is entertainment . . . but I feel most of those lyrics. (name, personal communication, October 18, 2021)

"I just remember like growing up, like we were really getting our like, our hood news from the music that came out. Um, Rondo going to jail, LA dying, all that good stuff. Those are just those came from those sources." (name, personal communication, January 25, 2022)

Participants discussed how Chicago drill music speaks to young Black Chicago in their own language. Many participants highlighted the manner in which Chicago drill music embraces and utilizes the creative and ever-changing “Chicago lingo,” described as creative words and phrases created and used by young Black Chicagoans. The Chicago lingo, often used in daily conversation and integrated into Chicago drill music, often includes catchy code words or phrases with hidden contextual meanings that give obscure details to listeners:

And then all of a sudden, they’re taking the natural lingo of Chicago, and creating it in a bluesy sound or created with some melodies where you like damn that’s so unique, you know saying it’s so catchy, or whatever. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

I have to attest it from the Chicago lingo, the pain . . . like we different. We sound different. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

Drill music is like a Chicago sound, like basically like it comes from the streets, survival. . . . You know like we got our own lingo. (name, personal communication, October 18, 2021)

It’s authentic and like every . . . all the other artists from different cities and states like they want to copy Chicago so bad like you know how you will be able to tell who from Atlanta who from Detroit, based off their lingo or, you know how they sound, everybody want to copy Chicago like we one of a kind. (name, personal communication, October 18, 2021)

But the thing about it was we didn’t purposely come out and say, “Oh, we rapping and this drill music.” We was really rapping about what was going on in our life in code, so a muthafucka, if you from Chicago, we be talking about some real shit in the song, if you not from Chicago and know the lingo, you just gone think it’s a cool song. However, a muthafucka from Chicago listening to it like, “no the fuck they didn’t,” you feel me. (name, personal communication, November 28, 2021).

As young Black Chicagoans navigate the various Chicago blocks and neighborhoods, young Black Chicago finds value in having a knowledge and understanding of navigating the various neighborhoods and understanding the numerous block/faction alliances and assumed or proclaimed gangs affiliated within those areas. The participants each spoke about how common,

normal, and expected it is for young Black Chicago to feel unprotected while attempting to participate in normal activities such as going to school or walking to the store:

You know, that's the same thing for me and being in my neighborhood, you know, I had to go through that neighborhood to get to school. I had to go from Woodlawn to Stony Island right, so I had to walk through they neighborhood. If I want to catch the bus or whatever to school, the police ain't finna save me. I gotta get my gun and save myself. Ain't no way around it. (name, personal communication, September 28, 2021)

Participants referenced their experiences navigating living in Chicago communities, experiencing the high rates of violent crime, and the constant lack of feeling safe or protected in their communities. The lack of trust and/or confidence in receiving fair treatment and protection from the Chicago Police Department has become a routine part of what young Black Chicago expects to experience. "It's not that people need to leave, it's just protection period. The police downtown and up north, they ain't where we at, and if they is, they harassing you" (name, personal communication, September 28, 2021).

Chicago drill artist lyrics often speak to the experiences shared by other members of young Black Chicago. The similarities in the artist's experiences create a connection of understanding with the young Black Chicago listening audience. "Everybody going through the same shit, different hoods going through the same shit" (name, personal communication, September 27, 2021). Participants discussed how they may not personally know the Chicago drill artist; however, living in the most segregated major city in the United States, in the most disadvantaged, historically redlined, isolated, and disinvested communities, uncovered common themes often discussed by Chicago drill music artists:

It is really desolate over there. Like, as desolate as like the 90s on the east side. Like you go over there at nighttime, you could wonder if anybody lives over there. Like I'm seeing like, every corner there's going to be a liquor store, a corner store, a church, a rehab spot. (name, personal communication, January 25, 2022)

Chicago drill artists speak to these issues in their music. The audience connects because the environment and circumstances are similar to what participants had experienced or anticipated, which elicited a connection with the artist or song that allowed participants to feel and understand the music in a deeper and meaningful way:

I'm not like a hip-hop expert, but which came out of the South. Which came out of like, just being broke. And people doing whatever it takes, like entrepreneurially like hood entrepreneurs doing whatever it takes to to get money. Um, right now, you get drill, which is like, we can't even make money no more. We just out here we, young we out here and we broke doing whatever we can. (name, personal communication, January 25, 2022)

Participants spoke about how a specific artist's song or experience may not be the same or as high risk as what is described in a Chicago drill song. These shocking, emotionally gut-wrenching experiences have become ingrained into what it means to be a member of young Black Chicago. "I'm 35, and I'm still alive. I only got shot one time, but I ain't really had a like a lot, a lot a lot of bad shit that happen to me" (name, personal communication, October 28, 2021). Participants detailed these experiences and situations starting at a very young age, usually between the ages of 10 to 14, and increasing in frequency and severity as the participants got older. The participants described their environment, settings, and experiences as part of their daily reality living in Chicago. These occurrences have become conditioned factors of everyday life:

Obviously, not everything in there is stuff that I've lived or seen. But it could be, you know what I mean? Like, I've come centimeters away from seeing that, right? Oh, yeah. So, none of that. Nothing that they be saying seems too far away. (name, personal communication, January 25, 2022)

Participants highlighted the disconnection between what is reported as "important" in local news media, political agendas, and Chicago headlines and the reality of the young Black Chicago experience. The participants viewed Chicago drill music as a means to expose the

conditions of Chicago's Black communities and share a real visual account and provide a narrative that speaks to the realities of their experience.

I think the harsh reality of what they're actually spitting, you know, singing, speaking, rhyming, is so real, obviously because we see it every day. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

What I love about drill music is it brought light to the dark of Chicago that a lot of people did not want to really talk about it I'm saying, like, when you control the narrative all the time. (name, personal communication, September 10, 2021)

Umm, lifestyle. you know when I, when I hear they music, it's what I do, or did do on everyday basis, so they just. . . . I want to listen to stuff. . . . I can't listen to Jay-Z because I don't got a billion dollars, but I can listen, shorty from 69th 'cause this is what we do. (name, personal communication, September 28, 2021)

I'm pretty sure, like most drill music songs. They'll have a street. They'll have a street telling you to like, What is going on everybody heard that we not from 63rd stuff, you know, That'll tell you like come on like this place needs to be cleaned up or people need to know like, why isn't this person found, why is this person guilty of committing these crimes, because these people that's getting shot, mind you they children or probably brothers sisters of somebody else. (name, personal communication, October 5, 2021)

The theme of shared experience, as demonstrated from the previous quotes, provides insight into young Black Chicago community members' outlook on mutual daily experiences often discussed in Chicago drill music lyrics. Young Black Chicago has grown to recognize and normalize the typical Chicago experience through this lens. The unique aspect of their perception is that these experiences are not confined to a specific Chicago neighborhood, nor are they limited to an individual with a specific background or education. These experiences are viewed as universal events, frequently occurring across widespread Black Chicago communities, ultimately impacting young Black Chicago community members views, behaviors, and way of life.

Chicago Gang Culture

Earlier research discussed Chicago gangs, their relationship to the demolition of Chicago Public Housing projects and "Operation Headache," and Chicago law enforcement's targeted effort to permanently dismantle Chicago gangs through the removal of high-ranking gang

members. In conjunction with these events, the impact of the crack cocaine epidemic and the “War on Drugs” left many single-parent, female-headed Black Chicago families displaced into poverty-stricken neighborhoods. These events eventually led to the fracturing of many Chicago gangs into various communities and neighborhood strongholds in certain areas. In recent years, some research has focused on the presence of gangs in the digital world and on social media. Little research has focused on the complete metamorphosis of Chicago gangs’ same-gang connections and/or rival-connected micro-cliques, which have become embedded into the social fabric of identity of many Chicago neighborhoods, schools, and other institutions. There also has been little research focused on Chicago gang cliques transitioning from the street economy into identifying legal opportunities for financial gain through the virtual economy. The transition of traditional Chicago gangs into gang-involved cliques has completely changed how young Black Chicago community members encounter contact with gang involvement and how they must now navigate their communities, local institutions, and daily interactions. The traditional narrative of Chicago gang members huddled in groups and standing on corners all disappeared. Gang affiliation has transitioned from street corners to now come in the form of specific neighborhood blocks of small cliques, assumed neighborhood or school gang affiliation, and even inherited gang ties. Young Black Chicago community members are often assumed to be affiliated with gang factions based on their street address, school enrollment, or assumed connection through family and/or friends. Based on being assumed as gang-affiliated through these loose connections, young Black Chicago community members often find it difficult to navigate day to day activities such as attending school, walking through the neighborhood, or even getting a job in a certain area or location in the city without the assumption of belonging to or being affiliated

Young Black Chicago community members often find it difficult to avoid or sometimes necessary to become “affiliated” with gang-involved cliques or individuals as a means for protection and/or survival. This affiliation becomes more widespread and recognized through digital and social media connections. It has become common practice in many Black Chicago communities that specific “blocks” or gang-affiliated areas are renamed and reidentified in honor of the death or murder of affiliated gang members:

Like when the news speak about it today, I be so pissed. Yea, the gang violence in Chicago, the gang. Gang and ain't no fucking gang violence in Chicago. Y'all already did that y'all. They fucked up with that by, you know, taking all the leaders away. So now everybody trying to fight for a top spot. You know, and then after the projects got torn down, you really can pinpoint. You know what I mean, everybody was in one area. Like it's not even no sets no more, you know, the person who died they call that area. (name, personal communication, September 28, 2021)

After people got killed, each block lost somebody. Each group lost somebody. It changed it ain't no sets no more. Everybody like is random, random cliques. And that's another thing. When, when everybody area got took from them, whether it be the projects getting tore down or what do you call it re-gentrification, yeah. So, for instance, like how Cottage Grove. That's a good, good example. From 61st to 63rd, it was like some little projects both sides of the street. They kicked everybody out from there and just displaced them just into just all neighborhoods, so like I said, if you have, this gang was from right here. Now they all moved. So now you on this block with these guys, you know, he might be a BD, he GD, he Stone, but fuck all that because we are from over here now this our shit so now this our clique we can't be under one gang no more. So now we got to clique, you know, and that's what it is. (name, personal communication, September 28, 2021)

Young Black Chicago community members often become introduced or affiliated with gang factions through no intentional action or behavior of their own. “I think it's like you don't even really gotta to be gang affiliated no more if you like live in the area they gone target you as you what they is” (name, personal communication, October 5, 2021). The new era of being introduced to Chicago gang affiliations now comes in the forms of social media, athletes, influencers, and artists. The emergence of digital social networks and streaming platforms has deepened the socialization and popularity of gang affiliation in Chicago's identity. Gang-related

content such as the popular viral song and video “The G.D. (Gangster Disciples) Anthem,” released by Chicago artist Rooga, can be heard playing on many popular urban Chicago radio stations and beyond, with recreated iterations of the song and video going viral on social media platforms. Young Black Chicago community members capitalize on digital economy by creating popular content, which gains popularity, views, and streams, resulting in opportunities for increased financial gain. This is also true for gang-affiliated individuals or groups. The presence of Chicago gang culture has been historically embedded into many Black Chicago neighborhoods. Community members of young Black Chicago have adapted their mentality, behaviors, physicality, and virtual presence to take into account the presence of Chicago gang culture while engaging in routine experiences.

Grief and Loss

Chicago violence has taken center stage in local and national media. Violent crimes in Chicago, such as shootings, have peaked at numbers as high as 60-70 individuals shot in one weekend. Young Black Chicago community members encounter murder, death, and violence at an extremely high rate. “Everybody knows what it feels like to hurt for somebody that you’ve lost, especially if you’re a young person in Chicago” (name, personal communication, January 25, 2021). All humans will at some time process the death of family and friends in their life. However, processing the deaths of young lives due to the intentional act of murder brings a significantly different element to processing grief and loss. There are many communities across Black Chicago, and members of young Black Chicago are experiencing collective grief, which occurs when a community is processing the emotional reactions and anger associated with an incident of violence occurring within the community. Continual instances of community violence

in Black Chicago have led to heightened feelings of being unsafe and mistrustful of other individuals or policymakers within the community.

“I remember when somebody died like you cried and shed a tear now somebody die it’s like, oh well. What are we eating for breakfast today? It’s um, what do you call it? Just numb, just numb. It happens so much” (name, personal communication, September 18, 2021). As noted in the participant quote above, young Black Chicago is interacting with death at such an extremely high frequency that the emotional reaction to death has led to a feeling of numbness. Participants often described the mental and psychological pain associated with witnessing or learning about the murder of close friends and family members. Young Black Chicago community members also interact with murder, death, and violence at a rate much higher and much more common than in previous generations. “People literally losing people weekly. Imagine losing double-digit people in one year” (name, personal communication, February 18, 2022). As noted in the previous quote, young Black Chicago community members are not only experiencing loss but also cumulative grief by having to process multiple deaths at the same time. The experiences with grief and loss are not only processed on an individual basis, but social networks and digital platforms have created an inescapable public venue in which individuals are attempting to process grief and loss while often being exposed to public comments and responses made by other, which sometimes includes individuals from opposing gang-affiliated networks. Chicago drill music is heavily influenced by Chicago gang culture and has also become a space where young Black Chicago processes the emotions associated with the instances of death, murder, and violence happening within the young Black Chicago community. “I think drill music just, just, it, it just personifies the pain” (name, personal communication, September 12, 2021). Chicago drill artists have often used their music to showcase their story

and environment, often including signifying connections to specific blocks, gang cliques, and other affiliated networks. This has also opened the music to be a vessel for taunting and/or threatening opposing cliques or “dissing the dead.” The act of taunting opposing cliques while expressing the emotional pain associated with grief and loss has become intertwined with Chicago drill music and further sensationalized by social media and other digital platforms. Participants highlighted that Chicago drill music often offers a space where individuals can openly express their emotional and psychological pain. This musical expression becomes a binding event that connects to the experience of other young Black Chicago community members.

Validation

The stories of Black Chicago communities have often been excluded from local media. Chicago drill music provides an expansion of real stories, videos, and reactions, occurring within the home communities of many young Black Chicago community members. Chicago drill music provides undeniable truth, shock, awareness, and hidden meaning to incidents happening across Chicago communities and within digital spaces. Young Black Chicago community members often dismiss traditional local news sources due to stories being excluded and/or inaccurately reported. Young Black Chicago community members often use social media as a way to stay updated on events believed to more accurately reflect relevant stories occurring within the Black community. Chicago drill music provides deeper insight and hidden innuendos about occurrences relevant to young Black Chicago. Chicago drill music provides credibility and proof that the shocking stories told through music are, in fact, real. Additional validation is provided through Chicago drill music videos and the artist’s social media activity. A participant discussed watching Chicago drill music and compared the experience with being captivated with watching

conspiracy theory videos. The participant noted that they could spend several days watching Chicago drill music videos and would be able to determine what groups were in conflict with each other and which individuals were connected with violent acts occurring within the community. Chicago drill music, gang-affiliated cliques, and social media activity provide verification that the stories behind the music are real and provide awareness and warning to outsiders or opposing individuals entering those specific communities.

Young Black Chicago community members take pride in their block and the reputation associated with the identity of that block:

Contrary to what “they” say, people take pride in they block still whether the world look at it is as the hood and everything. this what they wake up to every day. This all they know, and shit, it’s okay with them, they don’t know nothing different until, you know you get older and you get to experience shit, but even then, those life lessons that you learned in those kinds of environments is priceless. (name, personal communication, February 18, 2022)

Participants noted that young Black Chicago community members connect with Chicago drill music through the shared experiences of not being ashamed of living in poverty-stricken neighborhoods while being proud and interconnected to their “block’s” identity, unashamed to participate in the behavior associated with struggling to survive:

I ain’t saying it make poverty cool, you know what I’m saying, but it make a way of living a certain style of living cool. You know, whether you live in an environment like you could be living in that abandoned house that’s next to that building that is worth \$300,000 and be comfortable. It makes you be happy. It makes you feel happy and comfortable in your environment. You feel me, so I feel like that’s what allowed people to connect with it and then for them to be comfortable with it. (name, personal communication, January 20, 2022)

Vigilance

Young Black Chicago community members often express a need to constantly be alert and aware of the neighborhoods they are in, the individuals they are physically around, and the need to be prepared to respond to high-risk or even life-threatening situations. As young Black

Chicago community members navigate school, employment, or simple activities such as walking to the grocery store or going to a shopping mall, there is always a need to be conscious of potential risk. This heightened sense of alertness is often discussed and taunted in Chicago drill music lyrics. Artists may reference an individual being killed or seriously injured due to being “caught lackin,” meaning not being alert, aware, and immediately ready to respond to immediate risk in an individual’s environment. A simple act such as standing at a bus stop, sitting parked in a car to make a short phone call, or attending a party, could have grave consequences for opposing individuals. Chicago drill music and social media provide insight to young Black Chicago community members on any ongoing rival gang feuds, areas to avoid, and situations in which individuals are “set up” to be killed; clues on the street identified individuals are associated with these events:

I had to go through that neighborhood in order to get to school. I had to go from Woodlawn to Stony Island, right so I had to walk through they neighborhood, if I want to catch the bus or whatever to school, the police ain’t finna save me, I gotta get my gun save myself, ain’t no way around it. (name, personal communication, September 28, 2021)

You gotta be bulletproof out her No matter what you do, you gotta protect you and yours because I ain’t going in the club if I can’t go in the club go in the back door and the guns can’t go in with me, I’m sorry, or my protection gone sit outside that club. I’m not dying to go perform. I’m not dying behind nothing. (name, personal communication, October 18, 2021)

It just speaks volumes to the this like survival rate, and what you have to do to survive out here, and yeah, of course, that’s in the music. It’s when we express ourselves, right? So, of course, that’s in the music. (name, personal communication, January 25, 2022)

As noted in the quotes above, community members of young Black Chicago constantly function from a heightened sense of risk and very real perception that increased vigilance benefits their survival. Participants expressed that existing and going about everyday activities is calculated with risk from either encountering gangs, dangerous situations, or being unfairly targeted by police. The presence of metal detectors in school, blue flashing police cameras on

light poles in predominantly Black communities, and the lack of feeling protected by law enforcement officials are all factors that lead young Black Chicago community members to constantly feel unsafe and feel the need to protect and preserve themselves by any means.

Clout

Chicago has been at the forefront of conversations on violence locally and nationally. Chicago has even taken on the infamous name of Chiraq, Drillinois, a nickname made famous through Chicago drill music artist, King Louie. The term Chiraq, Drillinois was developed to compare Chicago neighborhoods and shooting violence to the war-torn areas of Iraq; and the constant sound of rapid gunshots happening across Chicago neighborhoods. The perception of Chicago gang feuds and violence has attracted the attention of millions, including capturing the attention of record labels, social media, and vloggers. Participants believed that violence has always been present in Chicago. However, it was made popular through the attention gained from being “famous or known,” which includes having a reputation that is widely spread across Chicago neighborhoods or having a significant presence or following and audience engagement on social media platforms. The term *clout* became widely used in Chicago through Chicago drill artist FBG Duck, who also referred to himself as “Big Clout” and his clique/entertainment company “Clout Boyz Entertainment.”

Participants described clout as a level of popularity or recognition an individual achieves from being the first to post viral images or video on social media or having a reputation connected to money, violence, or music. In the young Black Chicago community, clout can be beneficial. It provides an enhanced sense of importance, value, and stature within the community and may also deter others from committing acts of violence against the individual. Clout also can have a negative impact and make an individual a target for higher levels of violence. In young

Black Chicago, clout is often gaining attention through being known or connected to an incident or having a reputation for violence. Participants noted that clout can often be achieved by having a reputation for violence. Participants made statements such as “So you have people like posting and becoming hood famous” (name, personal communication, January 25, 2022), and:

The girls want the shooter. They want to the killer, you know, so now if you ain’t no known shooter, no known killer you know or y’all block ain’t on shit, y’all ain’t doing shit, so now don’t nobody want to hang out over there. I don’t know why people want to be where the danger is, but people want to be where the danger at, they want to be with the dangerous guy, you know, it’s popular. (name, personal communication, September 28, 2021)

Participants recognized the negative impact that clout can bring. However, the participants also recognized that having a name and popularity can often be the only thing a person has to offer, and it can be the only value the person sees in themselves. Having clout, a reputation for violence, a strong social media following, and a presence in music are often seen as the formula leading to capturing the attention of major record labels and can potentially lead to signing a major record deal, allowing the individual an opportunity to “get out” of their current circumstances.

Evolution/Resilience

The history of Chicago policies enacted in relation to the Black Chicago community has had a lasting impact on the Black Chicago community. The years of disinvestment to South and West Side communities is very evident when comparing the beautiful downtown area and North Side neighborhoods to Black Chicago communities on the South and West Side. Participants talked about “getting out” throughout the majority of the interview sessions. Each participant discussed the valuable lessons they learned over the years as a part of their young Black experience in Chicago. Some noted living through housing instability, violence, homelessness,

poverty, and unemployment. The participants were proud to share these experiences and noted that it made them stronger and more prepared to overcome any future challenges they would encounter. The participants all noted that they grew strength through hearing the challenges and stories shared in Chicago drill music because, for them, it resembled the same challenges they dealt with in their personal lives. The participants highlighted that they were happy that Chicago drill music had taken such a national spotlight. Participants stated that Chicago drill music really showed what so many people in Chicago struggle with every day, and the music solidified Chicago's place in the music industry while focusing attention on the issues happening in Black Chicago neighborhoods. Participants noted that they did not see anything bad about Chicago drill music, with the exception of the latest trend, "dissing the dead." Participants noted that they took pride in seeing Chicago drill artists' path from having "nothing" to ultimately achieving success and boasting million-dollar record deals, homes, and cars. Participants also noted that Chicago drill music provided a creative space in which they creatively expressed the painful experiences they encountered as a part of their young Black Chicago experience:

It's like it's just crazy for that one song to make that much that impact on like a community, you know what I'm saying, even like like people might think it might be a negative impact. But I feel like it's all positive because it sheds light on a community. That probably would have never been that it went through the same issue but never had light shed on it. That's why I like that song and what it did for you know what I'm saying Chicago, and that community O'Block, itself you feel me. (name, personal communication, January 25, 2022)

Participants recognized the impact of shining light on Chicago's most disinvested and forgotten neighborhoods through Chicago drill music and hoped that it would lead to further conversations to create change, opportunity, and hope for future generations. Multiple participants discussed the desire that many young Black Chicago community members have related to "getting out" of the hood. Participants noted that young Black Chicago community members have a desire to change and opportunity for themselves and their children. "It made me think that especially after

having kids, it made me think umm, this ain't no place I would want to raise my children. Especially like when you go to the other like states and stuff, you see better opportunities" (name, personal communication, November 29, 2021). Participants made the comparison that for many young Black Chicago community members being a Chicago drill music artist has is similar to the popular era of "hoop dreams" when many young Black males had the desire to become NBA players. The success of the many popular Chicago drill music artists such as Chief Keef, Lil Durk, G-Herbo, Rooga, and many others undoubtedly offers a perception that creating Chicago drill music provides a very accessible way to leave Chicago's adversely impacted communities and achieve a better quality of life. Participants noted that some young Black Chicago community members feel they have no value or hope for the future and are willing to risk engaging in high-risk lifestyles or even being murdered in pursuit of what they believe will bring them a better life.

Emerging Themes

Exploitation

In alignment with the themes gathered from participant interviews, two emerging themes were recognized, exploitation and the impact of the absence of lived experienced community mentors. Participants often spoke of the large-scale exploitation of poverty and violence in Black Chicago communities through the consumerism of record labels and digital platforms. Participants also highlighted the constant predatory business practices present in Black Chicago communities that play an active role in fueling violent activity such as smash and grab theft and carjacking.

Hip-hop and rap have always garnered their audience attention through the authenticity behind the music. Chicago drill artists often include stories connected to their background

experiences and neighborhoods of origin through their music. As social media and streaming platforms have become more prevalent, it has offered young Black Chicago community members an opportunity to promote themselves and their online personas. As dynamics in the music industry have changed over the years, music artists have the capacity to build an independent fanbase, follower network, and achieve streaming success prior to being signed by a major record label. This method has allowed many Chicago drill artists to generate revenue on streaming platforms such as YouTube. This phenomenon was present in the success of Chicago drill artist Chief Keef, the first Chicago drill artist to leverage social media and streaming platforms to build a foundation as an independent drill artist and sign with a major record label. As violence increased in Chicago, so has the interest in signing the most “authentic” rap artist. As more gang-affiliated artists grew in popularity and signed major record deals, the trend of gaining notoriety from being engaged in the Chicago drill music scene has continued to increase. Participants referenced the predatory nature of major record labels, coming to Black Chicago communities dangling hefty record deals before unsuspecting young Black Chicago artists. Participants noted that young Black Chicago youth are often desperate for a way out of their current environment and often sign the deal. The participants spoke of how the record labels are often the machine behind the artist and ultimately play a role in encouraging and glamorizing violence. Participants shared that artists often remain in the community while engaged in gang clique feuds and other high-risk online behaviors. This is extremely dangerous for the artist and eventually targets them for violence. The record contracts are often connected to large life insurance policies on the artist if the artist is killed and unable to fulfill the terms of the contract. The label benefits from the life insurance policy and the huge surge in streams and sales from the deceased artist’s music. Participants noted throughout the interviews that there is constantly the

presence of “outsiders” benefiting from the Black community. Participants noted that “outsiders” often receive the political and financial support needed to open businesses in Black Chicago communities, while Black community members do not receive support to open businesses and are outcast in other neighborhoods across the city. Participants spoke of the exploitative nature of “big business” record labels, social media, and streaming platforms, but also the exploitative nature of local Chicago gas station owners, beauty supply owners, and cell phone store owners that pay young Black Chicago community members to provide “security” for their business or encourage young Black Chicagoans to engage in criminal behavior for benefit. Participants noted that these practices are often not discussed but are common occurrences in Black Chicago communities.

Lived Experience “Big Homie”

Participants noted throughout the interviews the impact the loss of structure that the Black community has experienced due to older males of lived experience not being present in the community. Participants often referred to not having a “big homie,” which was viewed as an individual of lived experience who acts as a mentor or role model for younger adults. Participants often spoke of the lack of respect for the community, elders, and structure that has become rampant in the young Black Chicago community. Participants discussed that there has been a lack of guidance and accountability present in Black Chicago communities, and that is often not discussed or acknowledged. Participants further discussed the level of fear and confrontation older adults experience when attempting to have conversations with the younger Black Chicago generation about their behavior. Participants identified the benefits of having an individual of lived experience to connect with the younger generation to deter the high risk and violent behaviors that have taken precedence.

CHAPTER FIVE: DISCUSSION, CONCLUSION, AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The findings of this study offer insight and several valuable lessons. The first lesson relates to understanding the complexities of young Black Chicago community members and understanding how they process and navigate their daily life experiences. The second lesson learned relates to understanding how Chicago drill music offers a perspective highlighting how young Black Chicago community members manage and navigate poverty, violence, and Chicago gang culture in a digital society. The final lesson learned highlights how young Black Chicago has leveraged their technological skills and experiences with violence, poverty, and Chicago gang culture through Chicago drill music to share their narrative and as a means of self-preservation.

The first lesson offers insight into the need to recognize the complexities associated with the daily experiences of young Black Chicago community members. Examining Black Chicago communities from a historical to present-day perspective, structural violence has significantly impacted Black Chicago. Chicago's historical discriminatory housing practices, redlining, housing projects development and demolition, public school closings, segregated neighborhoods, and neighborhood disinvestment are all major factors that must be considered when understanding today's Black Chicago community. These acts have contributed to mistrust, isolation, lack of resources, chronic violence exposure, and the overall inequitable quality of life for young Black Chicago community members. The opportunity gap for young Black Chicago has continued to grow wider with poor neighborhood conditions, lack of safety, lack of access to quality schools, and unemployment/underemployment. Young Black Chicago community members often feel they are functioning through a series of daily calculated risks while navigating their experiences. These combined elements create a need to approach young Black

Chicago community members' experiences from a complex and multi-dimensional perspective. Setting aside the traditional conservative views on poverty, violence, gun control, gangs, and their presence in digital spaces, the creative expressions shared through Chicago drill music offer a unique perspective on recentering the conversation to focus on addressing the core needs of addressing poverty and disadvantage impacting many young Black Chicago community members.

The second lesson lends a perspective in highlighting how Chicago drill music offers a snapshot to understanding how young Black Chicago community members utilize digital platforms to manage and navigate poverty, violence, and Chicago gang culture. The South Side of Chicago has been recognized as the birthplace of Chicago drill music. The scenes of young people packed in gangways, pointing semi-automatic guns at the camera, and threatening lyrics, give pause to a visceral reaction for most. The low bar of expectations combined with a sense of devaluing the young, the low expectations of poor neighborhood conditions, gang exposure, violence, death, and murder have become routine parts of everyday living for many young Black Chicago community members. The negative experiences of young Black Chicago are recreated daily across different individuals from different neighborhoods, sharing the same types of experiences. Young Black Chicago has become desensitized to the constant exposure to adverse conditions seen in their environment and has normalized it as an element of what they expect to experience in Chicago. The normalization of these conditions and experiences is further demonstrated in viral social media and the development of Chicago drill music.

The continual feeling of taking calculated risks to navigate life daily is an experience shared across the young Black Chicago community. Chicago drill music connects this same experience in their creative expression. Chicago drill music must be processed from a deeper

perspective that seeks to gain insight into how poverty, isolation, disinvestment, violence, and inequitable access to opportunity have impacted the young Black Chicago community. Violence, poverty, and gang culture have been present in Chicago before the inception of Chicago drill music. The explosion of technology and digital platforms has highlighted and intensified the focus on these issues through the lens of digital culture.

The final lesson learned highlights how young Black Chicago has leveraged their technological skills and experiences with violence, poverty, and Chicago gang culture through Chicago drill music to share their narrative and as a means of self-preservation. The gut reaction from most is hyper-critical disdain, and even disgust for the perceived glamorization of gangs and violence demonstrated in Chicago drill music. However, these reactions must not discredit the narrative, stories, and experiences many young Black Chicago community members share. Digital culture, social networks, and music have become integrated components in the lives of most young adults. On the surface, Chicago drill music may appear to boast threatening personas used to posture and grandstand for attention. However, Chicago drill music has undoubtedly made a global impact. Chicago drill music has provided a voice for the critical issues facing many young Black Chicago community members. There also must be recognition of the resilience, digital skill, social marketing capacity, and streaming success connected with the skills and development Chicago drill artists demonstrate to build their following and listening audience to change their circumstances. Utilizing the basic free resources available, often a cell phone and social media page, Chicago drill artists and other drill content creators have created a footprint for digital viral marketing, contorting algorithms, and leveraging streaming success on digital platforms to create a self-developed online global brand. Chicago drill music has

amplified the stories of young Black Chicago and given an accessible means to create a way out of violence and poverty.

Practical Implications

Since conditions were fulfilled with this research, the following results should be considered. The results consist of the empowerment, redefining the narrative, acknowledgement, digital awareness, and virtual technology opportunities. Acknowledgement must embrace the voices and experiences of young Black Chicago, while recognizing digital spaces and music development as spaces for creative expression. This shift in mindset challenges the current narrative about Chicago drill music and recognizes empowerment through creativity, strength, and resilience.

Empowerment allows young Black Chicago community members to share and process their experiences openly. Young Black Chicago must be empowered through valuing their experiences with affirmation from a non-judgmental, non-disparaging approach. Accessing empowering physical and digital spaces provides flexibility to meet community members at their comfort level. Young Black Chicago community members have limited physical and digital spaces that are reaffirming and nonjudgmental spaces accepting for all. Creating reaffirming nonjudgmental spaces that value the experiences and emotions of young adults will support them in identifying healthy coping strategies and supportive spaces that allow them to express their emotions.

Redefining the narrative of Chicago drill music by valuing the artist and their music as individuals with lived experience also highlights and values the shared experiences of many young Black Chicago community members. Community members connect with Chicago drill music because they relate to and embrace the experiences of a similar character, background, and

environment. Chicago drill music provides a creative art of expression that represents the real experiences of many in the community. The young Black Chicago voice must not be silenced and must be shared from the community's perspective. Supporting the further development of creative expression would allow community members to have more knowledge and insight about their craft and messaging.

Acknowledgement

Black Chicago communities have experienced decades of structural violence and disinvestment. Community members outside of Black Chicago may view the challenges as deserving due to lacking the desire to achieve a better quality of life or unwillingness to get a better education, training, or employment. Individuals may view Chicago drill music as harmful. However, it is important to recognize the story and visuals the music provides. The experiences of young Black Chicago community members must be acknowledged, heard, and respected. The global viral attention that Chicago drill music has created can encourage greater systemic change. Individuals outside of the community may perceive these forms of creative expression as harmful. Young Black Chicago community members find their value and power in sharing the realities of their environment and the issues impacting them, which are often excluded in traditional media. The exposure of Chicago drill music can encourage others to be attentive and insightful about how they have contributed or continue to contribute to larger systems that promote structural and virtual violence.

Virtual Interventions and Resources

As younger audiences continue to gravitate heavily to social media and other digital spaces, it is important that community interventions and resources are present in those spaces. Community-based resources and interventions must adapt to provide resources on social media

and digital platforms. Expanding community interventions and resources would allow community organizations to connect to provide virtual intervention and support. Virtual content and online behaviors often escalate into larger physical confrontations. Expanding community-based services into virtual spaces provides early intervention to deescalate harmful online behavior while providing accessible support for young community members to express their emotions and feelings. Young Black Chicago community members are utilizing social media and drill music as a space to process their anger, rage, and hurt connected to the events happening in their environment, providing early virtual intervention and emotional support.

Enhanced Opportunities for Digital Development Creation

Many young Black Chicago community members are turning to digital spaces to connect with others, express emotions, create entertainment content, and pursue digital entrepreneurship. Chicago drill music demonstrates the skill and savvy of young Black Chicago, enhancing opportunities to educate and enhance the young Black Chicago community to engage in various aspects of production technology, music production, social media engagement, and virtual campaigns are all meaningful ways that leverage the digital skills community members possess. Developing programming that supports the continued development and growth of digital content creation and digital production supports the community's use of transferrable skills into paths that boost self-confidence and self-worth and increase financial stability.

Limitations and Future Research

While there has been much research dedicated to violence and gang culture and its impact on Black youth in Chicago, little research has been dedicated to understanding Chicago drill music. Most of the research available was dedicated to understanding gang violence and its impact on social media behaviors. Chicago drill music is a relatively new phenomenon, which

continues to grow in popularity on digital and social media platforms. Many articles study Chicago as it relates to violence and gang culture. Chicago is often the reference point for many articles on understanding violence and gang culture. Chicago gangs have also been studied when researching online content and behavior. Rap music as a subgenre of hip-hop expressions of urban violence has also been highly researched. This research looked at understanding the connection and feelings of young Black Chicago through music created in their communities and environment. This study provided a voice to young Chicago community members, empowering them to shape their narrative and share their perspectives while changing the trajectory of Chicago drill music. Future research should examine the emerging themes of the virtual exploitation of Black communities and the engagement of individuals with lived experience as a community intervention strategy. Understanding the role of exploitation in the Black community and the benefits of engaging individuals with lived experience in community resource efforts can change how other cultures perceive young Black Chicago and provide insight into useful community interventions that interrupt patterns of virtual and environmental violence in the young Black Chicago community.

Conclusion

The disinvestment in young Black Chicago is unsettling. The shared experiences and normalcy of navigating threatening environments, gang culture, violence, and murder are alarming. It becomes easy to shun, dismiss, and invalidate an individual's story and experiences. It becomes easy to write off an individual's behavior as ignorance or entertainment. The grit and pure will to survive it takes to navigate life as a young Black person in Chicago are no easy task. To simply contribute an entire generation of Black Chicago youth behavior to gangs and

entertainment eliminates the complexities of understanding Black Chicago youth and the historical structures that have brought this generation to where they are today.

Some may believe that Chicago drill music should be banned and that it is only gang and retaliation music to gain attention. Young Black Chicago community members have become aware of what is happening within their communities by engaging in Chicago drill music culture. They embrace their sound, they are proud of having a creative expression that belongs originated from their communities, and they are happy to be recognized for the creation despite its controversy. Chicago drill music has created an outlet for the young Black Chicago community to creatively express grief and loss, voice rage, anger, and frustration, and it is a sound that has been embraced and replicated across the globe.

Last, hip-hop as a culture has always been met with resistance. Rap music, the stories, and the content has constantly been challenged. There have been constant attempts to shun and silence young Black voices that share the stories of what it means to be Black and disadvantaged, from Public Enemy to N.W.A., Tupac Shakur, and gangsta rap to drill music. The voices and experiences of young Black Chicago have been globally amplified through Chicago drill music. Their experiences are real, and they utilize technology to tell their stories and meet their needs to survive. The world must listen, process, and embrace their shared experiences to truly understand their needs and create a better quality of life for the future of young Black Chicago.

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Appendix A

Coding Process

Figure A1

Coding Process

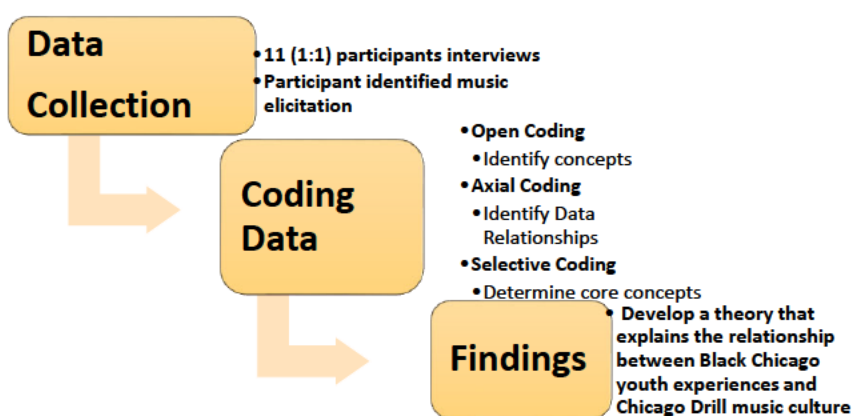


Figure A2

Themes

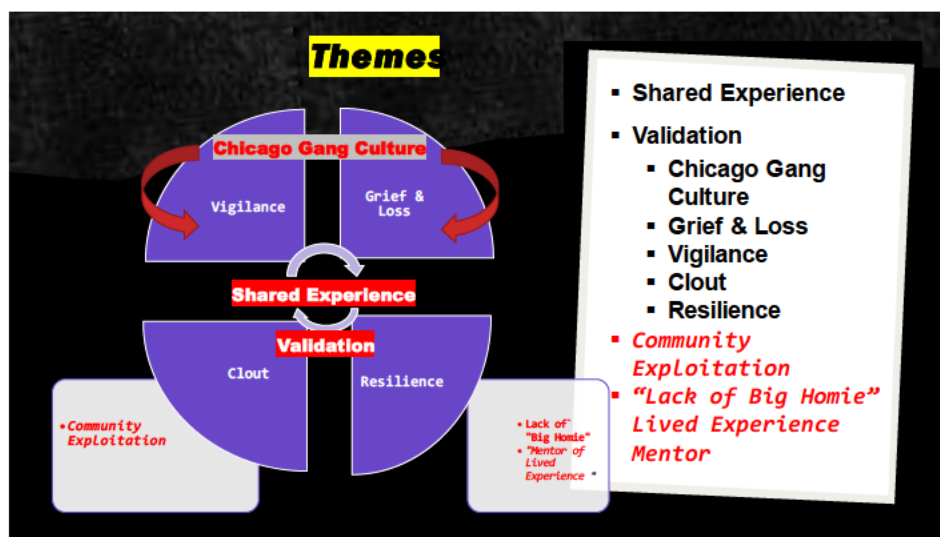


Table A1*Participant Interviews Emergent Themes*

Themes	Sub Themes	Code Indicators
Theme 1: Shared experiences • Violence • Murder/death • Neighborhood conditions • Negative police Interaction	• Communication • Connection • Normalcy • Financial means	• Chicago “lingo” language • Shooting offender and victim/lack of safety • Murder/loss one of family or friend • Targeted, lock you up, lack of protection, need to defend myself • Neighborhood conditions/ poverty
Theme 2: Grief and loss	• Pain • Anger • Retaliation • Depression • Revenge • Rage • Numb	• Death • Cumulative grief • Murder • Witnessing violence/death • Emotional pain • Coping mechanism
Theme 2: Validation	• Respect • Love • Recognized • Legitimate • Understood • Relatable • Acceptance	• This is reality • Someone that looks like me • Someone I can relate to • You’re like me • Your pain and trauma experience is identical to mine • Environmental similarities • Neighborhood similarities
Theme 3: Chicago gang culture	• Members • Affiliated • Alliance • Inherited/assumed neighborhood gang connection	• Gang war • Block • Clique • Factions/the “guys” • The other side • Opps/opposition

Themes	Sub Themes	Code Indicators
Theme 4: Vigilance	• Alert • Protection • Survive	• Caught lackin’ • Awareness of surrounding • Territories/block • Beefing • Target
Theme 5: Clout/value	• Entertainment • Financial gain • Reputation • Street/social media Influence	• Known • Popularity • Streams • Views • Dissing • Money
Theme 6: Evolution/resilience	• Raising awareness • Neighborhood impact • Legal means of employment • Creative expression • Emotional release	• A way out • Made it out • Come up • Still alive • Nothing to something
Themes	Sub Themes	Code Indicators
Emerging Theme 1: Community exploitation	Music labels Social media platforms Outsider(s)/predatory Businesses	Streams Views Record contracts/security Theft/carjacking
Emerging Theme 2: Big homie— individual of lived experience		

Appendix B

Coding Participant Quotes

Table B1

Coding Participant Quotes

Theme	Coding Participant Quote
Shared experience	P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P1, P2, P2, P2, P3, P3, P3, P3, P3, P4, P6, P6, P6, P7, P7, P8, P8, P8, P8, P10, P10, P10, P10, P10, P10, P10, P11
Chicago gang culture	P1, P2, P3, P3, P5, P5, P8, P10, P10, P10, P10
Grief and loss/ coping	P1, P2, P3, P3, P5, P5, P8, P10, P10, P10, P10
Vigilance	P2, P2, P3, P3, P3, P3, P4, P5, P5, P6, P6, P9, P8, P8, P9, P10, P10, P10, P11
Validation	P1, P1, P2, P2, P2, P3, P4, P4, P6, P7, P7, P7, P7, P9, P9, P10, P10, P10, P10, P10, P10, P10, P11, P10, P10, P11, P11, P11, P11, P11, P11, P11, P11
Clout	P2, P3, P3, P4, P5, P5, P6, P8, P10
Evolution/resilience	P1, P2, P3, P3, P3, P3, P3, P3, P5, P8, P11
Emerging themes	Coding Participant Quote
Net-ploitation	P3, P4, P4, P4, P5, P5, P6, P6, P6, P10, P11, P11
Lack of big homie—lived experience model/mentor	P1, P2, P3, P3, P6, P6, P10, P10, P10

Appendix C

Quotes

Table C1

Shared Experience

Participant	Quote
P1	Hmm, I think it began. For me, it would have began just from living in Chicago. Umm As a kid growing up the way I grew up on the west side of Chicago sparingly out South bearing witness to a lot of just the hood stuff like from people getting robbed, my mom getting robbed right in front of me. Seeing events, watching things happen, news, and then you're actually involved in things.
P1	Drill music, we will say that the founding factors of drill music is oppression
P1	I think the harsh reality of what they're actually spitting, you know, singing, speaking, rhyming, is so real, obviously because we see it every day.
P1	When I turned the corner abandoned buildings everywhere, dope lines all the way down the street, cocaine lines all the way around the corner, right, and you speak of what your environment entails.
P1	Even as a kid as a shorty over there it was. It was wild. And my sister was just talking about this last night how we want to Von Humboldt, and I ended up graduating from Stabin Magnet off of Hirsh and Bail and they tore down that oh but we went to Von Humboldt, seven, eight years old. My sister got stabbed when we was eight when she was eight, but we used to be fighting like every day. Every day at that school.
P1	Like, you know, they raised them up quick around there, like, you know that whole stereotype like Latinos use knives and stuff like, well, for us it was real, you know I was I can't say for anybody else but hell yeah they stabbed my sister twice. I remember snapping out, I was a kid too like 7-8-9 It was like it was crazy, crazy over there.
P1	And umm, but what I remember they culture like them Latinos used to stick together. You know what I'm saying like we was black. So- (obviously I'm Black), but we was black so now they will chase us home from school, but my mom used to lock the door and make us fight.
P1	The appearance is like rundown. We live in abandoned building and we had no water no heat when I moved in with my mom.
P1	The appearance was just like, night of the living dead, you know how you got people walking around like, that how it was just a whole bunch of we just called them hypes, crack heads and dope fiends, but that was the word for them hypes. So, it was just run down raggedy unkept.
P1	Chicago is one of the most segregated places that I know of, you know I'm saying, and I think it's it truly, truly plays a part in it

Participant	Quote
P1	The segregation I think really played a big part in it, especially when all the projects was up. You know what I'm sayin' you got all these folks in these projects and these little pockets. And its high rises to the twenty something floor or whatever however many floors it is per person. And you got thousands upon thousands of people living in them. And so much drugs that don't even make no sense. And then the gangs are running, obviously the enterprises to.... So, you know I'm saying protect they turf and and whatever man so, you know, it was just, I think the segregation really played a big part to sum it up though
P1	Right, it's easy to be on Fox Channel Five NBC, ABC, and I just show just the bad right oh today, five people were shot one day. But drill music was actually like the inside reporter, it became like the reporter, yall not going in there Channel 5 and all them, NO! They be on the outskirts, this is Tom Brokaw or whatever, you know that people got their names right. But in the hood, you had a fanboy, he was a reporter, you know, he reporting, I was right there when they came through, and they had a chopper which is an AK 47 And you know I'm saying, and shooting, and they came around and they found 125 shell cases damn 125 shell cases AK-47 shells and AR-15 so these shorties actually became reporters on the block.
P1	They made it popular with the lowest, the lowest slang terms and stuff like that, that made it poppin.
P1	And then all of a sudden, they're taking the natural lingo of Chicago, and creating it in a bluesy sound or created with some melodies where you like damn that's so unique, you know saying It's so catchy, or whatever.
P1	When you hear certain music, it brings you to a place and for me when I heard Demon for the first time, It brought me back to 16th and Millard , and it made me look at Pete, him taking his last breath and how I felt and how your mind turned.
P1	it gave those little kids who was in front of the TV, looking at SpongeBob and playing Call of Duty and the games, a voice of their pain like this is what we live through. And I'm outside I'm 13 years old, They just killed my homie who 13, and we call it a block, we done named the block after him now, in his memory, but it's 14 of us that hang together, and we got 20 something guns
P1	What I love about drill music, is it brought light to the dark of Chicago, that a lot of people didn't want to really talk about, you know what I'm saying like, when you control the narrative all the time
P1	I have to attest it from the Chicago lingo, the pain. Like we different, we sound different.
P2	Everybody going through the same shit, different hoods going through the same shit.
P2	They already said, I couldn't come over already like, "Aye get the fuck from around"! Then it started to they started shooting at me, every time they seen me every single time.

Participant	Quote
P2	That's like the youth they feel like shit why our schools gotta close down. Why these schools up North ain't closing down? Why we got to go over to this school where our oppositions at? Now we got to worry about our ass when we get up out of school. You know what I'm saying and dealing that. Damn why we ain't got enough books here but up North they got iPads and shit like that why we ain't got that. Hell Yeah, it's gone make the kids turn up. They feel some type of way.
P3	Umm, lifestyle. you know when I, when I hear they music it's what I do, or did do on everyday basis, so they just.... I want to listen to stuff... I can't listen to Jay Z because I don't got a billion dollars, but I can listen, shorty from 69th 'cause this is what we do.
P3	I'm 35 and I'm still alive. I only got shot one time, but I ain't really had a like a lot, a lot a lot of bad shit that happened to me.
P3	It's not that people need to leave, it's just protection period. The police downtown and up North, they ain't where we at, and if they is they harassing you.
P3	You know, that's the same thing for me and being in my neighborhood, you know, I had to go through that neighborhood in order to get to school. I had to go from Woodlawn to Stony Island, right so I had to walk through they neighborhood, if I want to catch the bus or whatever to school, the police ain't finna save me, I gotta get my gun save myself. Ain't no way around it.
P3	Somebody had one body, but when you done killed like six, seven people you're a serial killer at this point. So now you got like a city full of serial killers. You know, I mean, that's kind of that's deep if you really think about it.
P3	People in Chicago have become numb to murder, its bad as hell
P4	I'm pretty sure like most drill music songs they'll have a street they'll have a street telling you like, What's going on everybody heard that we not from 63rd stuff, you know, That'll tell you like come on like this place needs to be cleaned up or people need to know like, why isn't this person found why is this person guilty of committing these crimes because these people that's getting shot Mind you they children or probably Brothers Sisters of somebody else
P6	I'm here in the city, I know what's going on, I know a lot of people stories, and I can relate, and I know the truth versus the lies and it's like music is entertainment, but I feel most of those lyrics
P6	Like when you creating music you gotta make people feel you gotta touch them, Just like when people make music and you cry that's what it's like
P6	Drill music is like a Chicago sound like basically like it comes from the streets, survival. You know like, we got our own lingo
P7	I would describe it as Chicago, that's it! You just can't. don't give it. it's Chicago! Because every, every aspect of Chicago is in there, the grittiness, the story, its mixed, its everything mixed in.

Participant	Quote
P7	But the thing about it was we didn't purposely come out and say "Oh, we rapping and this Drill Music". We was really rapping about what was going on in our life in code, so a mother fucker, if you from Chicago, we be talking about some real shit in the song. if you not from Chicago and know the lingo, you just gone think it's a cool song. But a mother fucker from Chicago listening to it like, "no the fuck they didn't", you feel me.
P8	Growing up was pretty smooth. I'd say until about six or seven grade and I just started losing friends like I done lost about I wanna say almost everybody I went to grammar school with is dead.
P8	As far as like guys that was in my classes and stuff, like dead. I can pull about seven pictures that almost everybody in the photo dead due to gun violence in the street, gang banging or even rapping people putting names and people names in songs and getting caught lackin' in stores and getting killed
P8	The police left him out there for a long time, they couldn't cover his body to the left him out there for a long time. and it and was like just real shocking
P8	It's like seeing it and then just hearing about it is just different even, even when it's yours. Like one of yours, your people it's still different from seeing it cause it's like that that stuck with me for a while.
P10	I just remember like growing up, like we were really getting our like, our hood news from the music that came out. Um, Rondo going to jail, LA dying all that good stuff. Those are just some that came from those sources
P10	Obviously not everything in there is stuff that I've lived or seen. But it could be you know what I mean? Like, I've come centimeters away from seeing that, right? Oh, yeah. So, none of that. Nothing that they be saying seems too far away
P10	I'm not like a hip hop expert, but which came out of the south. Which came out of like, just being broke. And people doing whatever it takes, like entrepreneurially like hood entrepreneurs doing whatever it takes to to get money. Um, right now you get drill, which is like, we can't even make money no more. We just out here we, young we out here and we broke doing whatever we can
P10	We just have like a lot of overlapping factors. The most violent police force in the whole country, per the Federal Bureau of Investigation. We we've got all of these people, right the third largest population, but less actual jobs for all these people. Almost half of our population is Black yet, right we have majority black filled penitentiary. So, you just got all these overlapping factors that just points to like, Hey, y'all have to figure it out. and the "y'all" being, the younger generation of the time, like "y'all" have just got to create a new way. Create a new way to survive.
P10	We was getting chased in sixth grade, by the same same police officers that were contracted to be at our school you feel me? Um So like like these. These are the things that the pressures in our environment never like stopped being there never started like there were they were just always there for us.

Participant	Quote
P10	those guys, I was hanging out on the corner. They've been there since the beginning of time. My auntie know them people you know what I mean? So, these are things that's all this is just a part of our life. It'd be like if somebody that want to go to NBA rapped about hooping every day. It's not something that we chose, it just chose our life
P10	it's really desolate over there. Like, as desolate as like the 90s on the east side. Like you go over there at nighttime. You could wonder if anybody lives over there. Like I'm seeing like, every corner there's going to be a liquor store, a corner store, a church, a rehab spot.
P11	I remember my boy like nah you need to listen to this this where we at this the real stuff we going through this the stuff we living through even though they out south with it and then that's when they went on.

Table C2*Validation*

Participant	Quote
P1	Your pain and trauma is identical to mine and so on and so forth. I think that those are really big components
P1	What I love about drill music, is it brought light to the dark of Chicago, that a lot of people didn't want to really talk about it I'm saying like, when you control the narrative all the time.
P2	I mean, it's really what people going through out here in Chicago. If you ask me, and people gotta understand what people seeing and what people going through every day.
P2	That's why you go downtown and Hyde Park to fuck up they shit, because they feel like they taking all the money and putting it up north and downtown and they ain't doing nothing for the hood but stealing from our communities. Yes, that's a big issue and that's what make us our youth and stuff go drill on they ass. Yes. Yeah, to be real hell yea that's the big issue right there
P2	Everybody can relate to what mother fuckers talking about in the songs. For real, for real. That's just what it is.
P3	You know, so some of the music is like good, I made it out, you know. and you be like Damn I could relate to that, you know, I done made it out, I don't got to do this, I ain't on a block no more, you know.
P4	So, like, if it's not getting stopped, of course, people gone make songs like aye this is really going on. If you think is not, then the music will show you, or the media could show you like, that's really what be going on in Chicago.
P4	I say, the drill is to connect to Black Lives Matter, because like, you know, Black lives do matter, all lives matter, but like, drill music connect to Black Lives Matter because some black people, real life went through certain situations where made it seem like from another race that they lived, didn't matter.
P6	If you into the drill music tell your story without telling you the story
P6	I'm here in the city, I know what's going on, I know a lot of people stories, and I can relate, and I know the truth versus the lies and it's like music is entertainment, but I feel most of those lyrics
P6	I think it's important, like for a lot of people to like, like as for me, I let it be known like where I'm from and all that but I don't gang bang. all that is in my lyrics too. But it's like, it's important to remember where you come from, because it is what helped mold into who you becoming.

Participant	Quote
P7	You know contrary to what they say, people take pride in they block still whether the world look at it is as the hood and everything this what that they wake up to every day. This all they know. And shit it's okay with them they don't know nothing different until, you know you get older and you get to experience shit but even then, those life lessons that you learned in those kinds of environments is priceless.
P7	So the way of living is always going to be reflected in your it's kinda like an art it became a art for Chicago artists and shit it became an art in the release too you might go in there and rap about your opps so much you go let off the stress now you ain't even ready to go load your gun to kill them
P7	They rapping about this stuff because this is what they go through on a day to day basis within they community or neighborhood and stuff.
P7	What New York is going on, that's not drill! We wasn't in the video icy as hell. We wasn't doing that, it was real gritty. We just damn near came from outside, ain't nobody had a bath in three four days, you feel me done slept in the hallway trapping and everything. So, you got them raw videos, look at Sosa first few videos they wasn't fresh and shit you know
P9	It's like it's just crazy for that one song to make that much that impact on like a community you know what I'm saying even like, like people might think it might be a negative impact. But I feel like it's all positive because it sheds a light on a community. That probably would have never been that it went through the same issue but never had a light to be shed on it. That's why I like that song and what it did for you know what I'm saying Chicago. and That community O Block, itself you feel me
P9	I ain't saying it make poverty cool. You know what I'm saying, but it make a way of living a certain style of living cool. You know, whether you live in an environment like you could be living in that abandoned house, that's next to that building that is worth \$300,000 and be comfortable. It makes you be happy. It makes you feel happy and comfortable in your environment. You feel me so I feel like that's what allowed people to connect with it and then for them to be comfortable with it
P10	Young black, brown people but like life, life for us. is concentrated with risk. Like, you have to take the chance, right? There's not really a safe route.
P10	He was really talking about like, Oh, this is happening to us. And this is how we reacting to the world.
P10	it was just like those stories of like, we know that you feel this way, we feel this way too. But this one we doing about it.
P10	I remember first hearing that song and chills ringing down my spine as a 13-year-old kid. I'm just like having seen that right? Or like having been in those spaces it painted pictures that I've seen.

Participant	Quote
P10	It's like how hip hop began and in general, like a bunch of young black men, young black people, not not having anything to do. Young black men specifically going to jail and not having anything to do but write bars. About how they got there. Yeah, we just we out here we lost. There's no jobs, all we can do is talk about the life that we see and perpetuate that because that's what we see is right. Even if we noticed that it's wrong all you can do is express that it's wrong because there's nothing that we can do or even the people around us a lot of times can do to fix it.
P10	We got to protect this cause this other gang over here, might come over here and take capital. We got to protect this because we got control over the police force. Okay, we got many reasons, but it boils down to like we don't have anything else. So, this little four block radius this has to be ours hook or crook, um, and this is bled over into the music right because the music comes from the culture. But also, because it's it's that expression of we don't have anything but the house that we're walking out of it. Yall not taking this it's kind of revolutionary in a way
P10	More often than not, like just because of the numbers and like how it happens to us, more often than not, you'll hear you'll have a young black person in Chicago that's able to resonate with a story of losing their loved one and feeling angry. retaliatory
P10	I would ask them to listen to drill music from around the country. And listen to Chicago drill music. Listen to this, the difference and grittiness, I would ask them, why is it that it's 14-15-year-old people that like started this?
P10	the presence of police in our drill music you know what I mean? Yet, they get \$2 billion dollars every year. Like on the line so if you have people from your city whose voice was loud, passionate enough palatable enough to hear these, these stories that are very much so for the most part true. Some have some slight exaggerations. Even then, it's so that you can get the point. Wow. Why don't you address these problems? It'll be easy. ummm plenty of bars about police. umm stopping me for nothing. Why don't you start addressing some of these bars Plenty of bars about people not having jobs? About how our neighborhoods look right about what it's like to grow up in the with only liquor stores and churches. Policing ain't solving solving murders, so I got to do it myself. Why does it have to be like this? Why is all these bars that they're saying? Not not really like a glorification of the situation. Or even as much as description but really a critique of the world that they that's been pushed upon them. Why don't we do something about change?
P10	I think drill music, in and of itself gets a lot of harsh criticism. Hip Hop gets a lot of harsh criticism. But all it is, gang culture gets a lot of harsh criticism, but all of this was started by 12 to 15-year-olds that didn't have nothing else to do. So, lay off.... we just try to figure it out

Participant	Quote
P11	Personally, I would describe drill music as a culture, a movement, and era. So, I'm basically just touch basics on each topic A culture because drill is in a state, a city, a country, you know what I'm saying and there's history, historical history, black history behind the drill music. First of all, so that's the culture of it you know what I'm saying like, it's a thing and then the movement behind it is okay We got people that actually took this and put the world on it and made people that's not a part of the culture. Want to be a part of the culture that's our movement.
P11	But like if you really started listening to these rappers like they telling you a beautiful story about the real-life shit that people go through that a lot of these people still going through
P11	I feel like that right there that sound it went from like just dark. like yea that's just what it is, like we finna kill just everything, like everything negative... to like yeah, we from the hood... Yeah, we fucked up yea we had roaches and rats yea we was killing yea we lost people but you know what I'm saying, it's that "but" behind it now. Like "but" we in this position, "but" we still alive, "but" we still got momma nem, "but" you know so when you put the "but" behind it, that kinda give it that second chance that new daylight that new vibe.
P11	I'm talking about the real shit that people I lost, you know what I'm saying. All that shit that's drill too cause if people died to the streets that's drill. Shit done went on and you done lost mother fuckers and you wanna free yo dog, you know what I'm saying you got real, real niggas you know, you got real shit going on
P11	A lot of people be like I don't want to hear that sad shit nah you don't want to hear the truth. The truth that's what it is you, one of them people that run away from the truth. You don't want to hear the truth, they speaking the truth. And that's what's fucked up in music, like people, people get infatuated with hearing bullshit. You want you need to hear the truth, cause once you hear the truth you got again your real mind your real thoughts your subconscious now it's making sense to you.
P11	Chicago like, I'm proud of Chicago even with all the drill shit and all the mess that done happened. I'm proud of Chicago because it's like man, we on the map, all these people that keep coming up from Chicago. I'm like Damn that shit crazy
P11	Contrary to what they say, people take pride in they block still whether the world look at it is as the hood and everything this what that they wake up to every day. This all they know. And shit it's okay with them, they don't know nothing different until, you know you get older and you get to experience shit but even then, those life lessons that you learned in those kinds of environments is priceless.

Participant	Quote
P11	So the way of living is always going to be reflected in your it's kinda like an art it became a art for Chicago artists and shit it became an art in the release too you might go in there and rap about your opps so much you go let off the stress now you ain't even ready to go loaded your gun to kill them as much the video doing a lot of views you like okay cool you shit I'm finna just start keep saying negative shit about them because that's what's working if it wasn't they'll still be running back to the street trying to get busy
P11	It's just surroundings its simple, its surroundings. Some people might bend they surroundings and alter it a little bit like, you know, over exaggerate on the car they got but for the most part, it's a reflection on your life shit. So, if you put it in that song, that's probably your reality. Whether that be good or bad, and in between, sad whatever

Table C3*Chicago Gang Culture*

Participant	Quote
P1	We moved to Terror Town, not out south like in Chicago its two Terror towns, now people know that it's a Terror Town out south, that they speak on with a lot of Stones and GDs and BDs whatever , but I grew up in a Terror Town on Madison, Kedzie, Lake. Kedzie, you know what I'm saying Sacramento, all up through their, Washington. Black Souls, GDs real big. You know you got outskirts little gangs, but it was really mainly and Souls and GDs over there.
P2	Just being from where I'm at, the guys from other side didn't want to hear, "I'm not own that". You know at that time, you from over there nigga you with that shit. And that was it!
P3	Like when the news speak about it today, I be so pissed. Yea the gang violence in Chicago, the Gang. Gang and ain't no fucking gang violence in Chicago, y'all already did that y'all. They fucked up with that by, you know, taking all the leaders away. So now everybody trying to fight but a top spot. You know, and then after the projects got, you really can pinpoint. You know what I mean, everybody was in one area. Like it's not even no sets no more, you know, the person who died they call that area.
P3	After people got killed each block lost somebody each group lost somebody it changed it ain't no sets no more. Everybody like is random, random cliques. and that's another thing. When, when everybody area got took from them, whether it be the projects getting tore down or what do you call it re- gentrification, yeah. So, for instance, like how Cottage Grove. That's a good, good example, from 61st to 63rd it was like some little projects, both sides of the street. They kicked everybody out from there and just displaced them just into just all neighborhoods so like I said if you have this gang was from right here. Now they all moved. So now you on this block with these guys, you know, he might be a BD he GD, he Stone, but fuck all that because we are from over here now this our shit so now this our cliques we can't be under one gang no more. So now we got to clique, you know, and that's what it is,
P5	By the time I was, like, at least 14 going on fifteen. I was hanging out with gang members I was doing whatever they needed me to do. Because it wasn't just because of music it was because also family issues I had going on. Just to bring money in the house, I, I used to do freestyling, stuff like that write my own music, whatever
P5	I mean, like, their lifestyle that they was living. even JoJo before he got killed at the age of 18..... Like I was, I seen, day to day gang violence, I'm around it pretty much- I ain't gonna say 24/7. But whenever I do go to my like my little hangout spot, I'm around it every day... we have rivals pull up to headquarters, and we have to pretty much push 'em out.

Participant	Quote
P5	I was so young getting into hanging out with gang members, listening to that music around them. And eventually, getting to where I became one of them
P8	I think it's like you don't even really gotta to be gang affiliated no more if you like live in the area they gone target you as you what they is. I think that gang factions are tied into drill music because that's the main reason that people are drilling it's like war, like we from where we from, those are the enemies. You already know what comes with being enemies, you gotta take care of that so I feel like now people just speaking on it, because like I said, people have been dying or whatever
P10	So, to me it just comes out of that hunger. It comes out of that. Chicago, Chicago gang culture specifically,
P10	Well like Chicago gang culture, which started gang culture for the world. I mean for the rest of the country
P10	We had a elementary school, three blocks away called Barton. Why would these two elementary schools be fighting granted, the two sides were opposite gangs, like y'all probably got cousins that go to this school
P10	Like on 79th and Ashland so there's no like, deep running gang ties over there. Um, I had a cousin that used to get jumped every day by the gang. That was like he was part of Killer Ward. And these other people were claiming to be Killer Ward and so they were jumped him just for the name

Table C4*Grief and Loss*

Participant	Quote
P1	I think drill music just, just, it, it just personifies the pain
P1	A trend has started because the sound, and then that, to be able to nurse your pain, you know what I'm saying, to be able to nurse your pain, to be able to nurse your pain is like amazing so creatively
P1	So the drill music in and of itself, the effects of it and what it embodies, I think is like a gumbo, it's a whole bunch of a whole bunch of different sounds, that's released in that that person's pain.
P2	Drill music, the whole Drill shit, it played a big part I lost a lot of niggas out there in the streets.
P3	It's a cry help in so many words, because if you didn't want anybody to know about it you wouldn't speak about it. You want some somebody to listen you.
P3	I remember when somebody died like you cried and shed a tear now somebody die it's like, oh well. What are we eating for breakfast today? It's um what do you call it? Just Numb, just numb. it happens so much.
P3	Don't nobody know how to cope with the shit. You cry you a bitch, but sometimes, someone needs to cry. They need to forgive, you know, that should be talked about forgive, forgiveness. forgive that, forgive them. Sometimes somebody make a mistake. Sometimes somebody like for me, for instance, sometimes somebody don't even want to do that shit. You don't want to be out here like that.
P4	Some drill music songs be a cry out for help.
P6	It's a lot of hurt behind that drill music now. A lot of hurt a lot of mothers will never get to hug they sons and they daughters no more. A lot of kids will never know what it feel like to grow up without a mother, father, like that's devastating.
P6	Cause you never heal from grieving anyway that's not gangster, being gangster is making a difference
P8	I had to tell his momma that yo son just got shot and that it kind of took a toll like it kind of made me like real sad because um I think that was like the first time I ever seen something so tragic.
P8	It's like it just started becoming rapid like when you hearing about people getting killed. Oh, this person died yeah this person died. You kinda get adapt to it, like, you just get used to hearing that people gone, like you don't really even be hurt no mo.
P8	You just be like, Damn, I'm missing you, I don't really shed tears a lot of f times until I go to the funeral I guess it's like just don't hit me till I get there. Like damn they really gone so I might look like I'm okay but sometimes I don't be okay because people that I don't be expecting to leave be leaving.

Participant	Quote
P9	Violence and a lot of people that lost so now you got people that lost being guided by violence with the with the drill.
P9	Because I feel like that the art form that the artist is able to paint is they best painting that they can form with the art that they know how to create.
P10	Everybody knows what it feels like to hurt for somebody that you've lost, especially if you're a young person in Chicago
P11	People literally losing people weekly. Imagine losing double digit people in one year. Imagine losing your whole family, immediate family, because of some shit you did.
P11	Imagine sitting somewhere because of what you did. So, it's a lot of depression, it's a lot of regret. it's a lot of heartfelt shit, it's a lot of that shit.
P11	A lot of people taking that route and talking about the hurt side of it like the real, real side of it, which is the real side! Like, whether you whether you get touched or whatever, when you lose somebody when you sit down it hurt its pain behind it.
P11	Like we humans, we feel pain. Pain is also psychological

Table C5*Vigilance*

Participant	Quotes
P2	Now you got to worry about the police and all that other shit, you just became a target, you a target if you a rapper period.
P2	And then when everybody died and got locked up, I was like left alone to fend for myself, by myself. So, I guess that was a hard time because now I have to go from trying to be a pretty boy you know with the girls to now I gotta, I gotta shoot to survive. You know what I mean. I guess that's a big, big deal, and I didn't want to, but I had to.
P3	There's only so many jobs that you, then even if you do get a job, how are you gonna get the work without something bad happening to you.
P3	It's not that people need to leave its just protection period.
P3	You got to protect yourself, that's why everybody got a gun.
P3	I had to go through that neighborhood in order to get to school. I had to go from Woodlawn to Stony Island, right so I had to walk through they neighborhood, if I want to catch the bus or whatever to school, the police ain't finna save me, I gotta get my gun save myself. Ain't no way around it.
P4	Some drill music songs be like yeah yo homie next
P5	Just my main thing is be aware of your surroundings when you go out that way, you're not running into particular people you see in a video. But not just them. Be aware of all your surroundings. If they go, whatever, watch what they're reaching for. Because if you're not, you're gonna be an innocent bystander, laying on the ground, dead, crying for help or end up in a body bag
P5	that's why I move the way I move I don't upload a picture or nothing until I'm gone. Unless it's a show. And half the time I don't even post them videos until I'm out the door because it's just been too much like somebody would be, oh I just seen [REDACTED] I should have killed [REDACTED]
P6	just imagine you being an artist, and you could lose your life going in or outside of a facility like it's tough
P6	You gotta be bulletproof out her No matter what you do you gotta protect you and yours, because I ain't going in the club if I can't go in the club go in the back door and the guns can't go in with me, I'm sorry, or my protection gone sit outside that club. I'm not dying to go perform, I'm not dying behind nothing,
P9	You supposed to know what's up. you gotta stay strong, you gotta Stay solid. Um, especially in Chicago
P8	Especially in with these areas where the crime rate is like high and you damn near gotta watch every car that go past, especially in the summertime. You got to watch every car to go past if the person that don't that look suspicious, walk down the street. We need to know who is that who sent you because people come shooting and they come doing stuff real quick and out of nowhere

Participant	Quotes
P8	My first friend had passed away, I was actually with him when he we got killed. We just like just outside playing and we was going I think we was finna go to somebody's party and we was going past the church, and a car just came out the alley and just yelled his name and shot him right in his stomach
P9	Chicago is so treacherous, and when I say treacherous is in this amount of, I mean, like, violent. I feel like the violence in Chicago and it always it always was violent.
P10	It just speaks volumes to the this like survival rate, and what you have to do to survive out here and yeah, of course, that's in the music is when we express ourselves, right? So of course, that's in the music
P10	I'm from Auburn Gresham, South Englewood now or North Beverly, whatever the real estate people want to call it, but just like that, it's kind of like no man's land, it feels like. There's no jobs over there, it's the run of the mill liquor store, church on every corner, like literally every corner. On 79th Street, over there like South West of Chicago is known for snakes,
P10	Young black brown people but like life, life for us. is concentrated with risk
P11	But you know, music is also an instrumental weapon in the militant war that's going on in the City of Chicago like aight it's psychological we can talk about the people that they lost. We can talk about what we finna do to them get in they head so we can either have them play they self or let them know we really coming for you.

Table C6*Entertainment/Clout*

Participant	Quote
P2	They saw as a way to get a check and try to get up out the hood
P3	The next group be trying to up the last group or just up this crew of guys, you feel me.
P3	When I was a shorty, it's the guy who dressed the nicest who had the best car, who was getting some money who doing something with they selves like that's who the girls want, but now it's not like that no more. The girls want the shooter, they want to the killer, you know, so now if you ain't no known shooter, no known killer you know or y'all block ain't on shit, y'all ain't doing shit, so now don't nobody want to hang out over there. I don't know why people want to be where the danger is but people want to be where the danger at. They want to be with the dangerous guy, you know, its popular.
P4	People got mad at him for making a song called Drill time. People knew like well Chicago mfs like bro you not even like the whole time he doing it to make money
P5	So that's why everybody keeps coming out with new stuff they're doing this, they're doing that. But honestly, this is all you're chasing when you're making videos, because YouTube is paying you for video. So, let's talk about whatever platform you're putting them on, you're getting paid for it, that's all their after the money and the fame.
P5	A lot of them don't need a reason, they just do it for entertainment.
P6	Because a lot of people who come from here and who's real audience they have millions and millions of fans, they have millions and billions of streams and it's like everybody want to, like, a lot of people want to come to Chicago, want to go to these places and experience it even if it cost them they life they don't care
P8	Yeah, I think they think that they become like a lil hot like you only trending for a while. You get yo lil 15 minutes of fame and then you back to being a nobody, and then you back with the feds on you, just with a case.
P8	It's just as long as you're not in it it's just it's good to trend or its good to like, it's like good entertainment. Like oh these people into it, but they probably don't know how serious like they thinking this just with music when really this in real life.
P8	People who don't or never been here or don't know people from the area and stuff wouldn't know that this is stuff they really talk about or how serious and deep it is so they just looking at it from the outside look like everybody else from the outside looking in and thinking it's funny and stuff until somebody retaliate or they see that something get done and then, they probably show a difference

Participant	Quote
P10	I guess I can't remember like the first time, but it just be like, a lot of people talking about the same names and they like Oh, I gotta get on. YouTube and look this up and find out what's really going on out here. Oh, also, Instagram was just becoming a thing. So, you have people like posting and becoming hood famous.

Table C7*Evolution/Resilience*

Participant	Quote
P1	Everybody evolves grows change.
P2	It helped me open my eyes up and learn from they situations, really to understand that streets ain't shit but a lose lose you know what I'm saying, you gone have to battle the police and you gone have to battle them niggas you know all that shit come with the whole drill. So, shit it helped me shit It helped me wake up, it helped me value life more
P3	I mean some make you feel like you know you made it out the struggle.
P3	They talk about they struggle and look where they at now.
P3	That's another thing that, you know, I forgot to put in people like that, like underdog story they see somebody come from nothing, like Chief Keef,
P3	It started off as one thing and then, you know after Chief Keef got famous with it. It was like a way out now
P3	And you can make it out faster than basketball and sports, you know, Chief Keef got famous in like three months
P5	Stay positive have a positive outlook, and also demand that like. Yeah, I know I'm considered youth, but we need to be able to guide the younger youth in that right direction
P8	It made me think that especially after having kids it made me think umm this ain't no place I would want to raise my children. Especially like when you go to the other like states and stuff you see better opportunities
P11	And like I said, energy can't be destroyed it can only be transformed. So, whether its dark energy, whether its sanity, it can only, it can't be destroyed it ain't going nowhere. It's only gonna get more depressed, more dark, more. You know what I'm saying or, it's gonna be transformed into aight confidence umm what's the word that they use manifestation shit like that. I'm gonna take this and boost it.

Emerging Themes

Table C8*Lived Experience Guidance/Net-ploitation*

Participant	Code
P1	One of the biggest components to help a person is someone that they look at that's like me, you're like me, you know, you're like me, you're somebody that I could relate to you're somebody that look like me, you sound like me.
P2	Yeah, they scared of them they running from them. You feel me like the youth need us.
P3	Drill music like real were it started at. And it wasn't, you know they wasn't really looking at no avenue or no way out, they were just dissing the guys over there they ain't think they was gonna get famous off of it, you know, King Louis and Chief Keef made it the possibility aye people watching our story, we can get rich off this, you know, it's basically like exploiting. Everybody doing it right now. I seen a guy with a British accent with a drone, showing wearing people in Chicago got killed and gangways and showing the maps that the killer could have took, he's getting a YouTube check.
P3	The news speak about it today, I be so pissed, "Yea the gang violence in Chicago, the Gang". Ain't no fucking gang violence in Chicago, y'all already did that y'all, they fucked up with that you know, taking all the leaders away
P6	They need to teach them about leadership, they gonna need a stipend because what if they don't have any money. And they need to like teach them like right from wrong, like if you do this type of music or you make this type of decision every choice you make there's gonna be a consequence behind it whether it's good or bad
P6	it's like there isn't any guidance or anything like see when I was growing up, I never considered anyone that's a Big Homie or anything but I always had people like who had a voice I'll say or like, who kinda had power because if people listen to you that's powerful like whether it's music or if you try to help make a change in the community or whatever like that is like nowadays is not no structure like so if you try to go tell a little girl or boy, or a young guy like, oh, this ain't the the right thing to do, they'll probably kill you, they don't want to hear that
P10	we get to be a huge problem with no leadership Right? Or with non-apparent just not apparent leadership. And it shows through the music. You got like 14, 15-year-old people hopping on tracks calling themselves OG's. You got rights think. Herb was 15,16 and when he came with a track, like really talking about younguns and your, 16
P10	One of his little mixtapes and he's like talking about crackhead dads. Right. No big homies. You're talking about like, like just being lost in the streets. figuring out a way I think honestly, that's the element of whole drill music for me.

P10	I'll just speak from my experience. I didn't have a dad you feel me, and my mom was selling drugs, boosting purses, whatever part time job downtown that was seasonal. We didn't have no role models in the crib
Participant	Net-ploitation
P3	That's why I believe that it is so powerful when and you know it happened so damn quick. Literally, somebody was showing it to me I was laughing at him like, man, this shit is not it's not gonna go nowhere these little dirty ass boys, and then literally three months later he got a deal for like 3.6 million.
P4	it really life be making them feel good to the aspect where they think they oh yea this shit cool I'm gonna do this shit too try to shit it out. Whole time they not really with that or they they want to be or they probably do it for some clout, you never know.
P4	The reason it's getting so cool for everybody else, is they see it on the media it look cool to them all these people having fun making these music and everything.
P4	So that's what it really is everything on the mainstream media at this point. Everything publicized, so like, it's like an ongoing cycle.
P5	So that's why everybody keeps coming out with new stuff they're doing this, they're doing that. But honestly, this is all you're chasing when you're making videos, because YouTube is paying you for video. So, let's about whatever platform you're putting them on, you're getting paid for it. That's all they're after the money and the fame.
P6	Because a lot of people who come from here and who's real audience they have millions and millions of fans, they have millions and billions of streams and it's like everybody want to, like, a lot of people want to come to Chicago, want to go to these places and experience it even if it cost them they life they don't care.
P6	we have people like YouTubers and bloggers or people who just fans of music, like everybody around the world saying they not from 63rd. You would think that they from here they ain't some people never even been on 63rd or probably never even been to O'block.
P6	I want people to know like, I don't like that the outside world be helping to stir up BS. You know like everything like is authentic, the music and what people got going on but it's like, they don't make it no better with what people trying to do like people trying to make it out, you know, and there's like they help instigate and store up BS and I don't like that.
P10	But yeah, I think it's that allure of like, talking about the fads you know what I mean? The fads that 80% of the people that talk about it have never seen.
P11	as far as the people that control these labels and control the music the radios and all that, they know that too.